SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 1

Know Yourself Kindly

Where your lens came from, who you are now, and who you are becoming



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 1: *Know Yourself Kindly*.
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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. Every workpaper is free to print or fill in on the website: the book names it and gives a code to scan. *The Workpapers: Free Forms, All in One* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Chat analyzer”. You use it and it gives you something back.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12 (online) says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16 (online) about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 1 · ONLINE: PART ONE · THEN

Know yourself: then, where your lens came from

Why you expect what you expect, and how the rules you picked up growing up still make small decisions for you today.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. You're not one thing
2. Your lens came from somewhere
3. Each stage of growing up asks its own question
4. When something happened matters
5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts
6. An old rule can read other people for you
7. Write down the rulebook from home
8. You get to choose which rules to keep
9. The past isn't yours to change. What you carry forward is
10. The ideas, one at a time
11. You, in all your relationships
12. Inside you, and between you
13. In the individual program
14. The fields behind this part
15. In real life
16. Common mix-ups

This is where the book begins. Part One (Then, Now and Next) is about you. Part Two (a Preface and Chapters I to V) is about the people you share a life with. Part Three (Chapters 1 to 17) is about how people work. Some printed copies hold only one or two of the parts; every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, and the book at a glance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-start-here) there gives a one-minute tour of the whole thing.

IN SHORT:

- **You're not one thing.** A reaction comes from your wiring (it stays), the patterns life taught you (they can soften) and today's conditions (they pass). This part is about the patterns.
- **Your lens came from somewhere:** home, school, culture, money and what you lived through. Each stage of growing up asked its own question.
- **Some old rules were learned without all the facts,** and they can read other people for you: "Whoever notices, does it."
- **Write down the rulebook from home,** then choose which rules to keep.
- **The past isn't yours to change.** What you carry forward is.

SUNDAY, 10:15AM

Your partner is still in bed and the kitchen is a mess. Before you've had a single thought, you feel it: "Of course. It's always me." Nobody said that. But in the house you grew up in, whoever noticed the mess cleaned it. That old rule just made a decision for you.

Or, living alone: Since his wife died, Ray's house is quiet and nobody will see the dishes. He still can't sit down until every one is done. Nobody is watching. An old rule from the home he grew up in still is.

01

You're not one thing.

A reaction usually comes from three places at once: how you're built (your wiring, which stays), what life taught you (patterns, many of which can soften) and what kind of day you're having (conditions, which pass). This part is about the middle one, the patterns life taught you. Now (page 27) looks at the other two.

02

Your lens came from somewhere.

Family, school, friends, culture, money at home and what you watched all taught you what to expect: of yourself, of other people, and of how a "good" partner, parent or friend behaves. By adulthood your lens doesn't feel like a lens. It feels like simply seeing. Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) walks through it, and you can read one section and stop.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: the rules from home aren't good or bad, they're just yours to have a good sniff at. A fun first look is how you like to talk.

TOOL **Communication style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

03

Each stage of growing up asks its own question.

Is the world safe? Can I do it myself? Am I capable? Where do I belong? Can I be close without losing myself? And later in life: What am I building? Has my life meant something? The ages are rough and people move at their own pace. The answers you landed on can become understandings you keep using as an adult.

04

When something happened matters.

An experience that touches the question you were answering at the time tends to go deeper. A move at 4 is mostly about routines. A move at 14, in the middle of "Where do I belong?", can leave a longer feeling of being the outsider. Deeper isn't permanent, though: people keep learning all their lives.

05

Some old answers were learned without all the facts.

"I'm only okay when I'm useful." "My needs are a burden." "Mistakes mean I'm bad." A child often can't know what was going on for the grown-ups. They only know how it felt. As an adult, you're allowed to look again with the full picture. Looking again doesn't mean deciding it was all fine, because some things really were not okay.

06

An old rule can read other people for you.

If silence at home meant anger, a partner's quiet evening can feel like trouble is coming. And an expectation nobody said out loud can't be agreed to, so the other person can only miss it: "If you loved me, you'd just know." "Whoever notices, does it." Each is somebody's family rule, not a law of nature. Ask before you conclude: "When you went quiet, what was going on for you?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When an old rule jumps in before you've had a chance to think, you don't have to argue with it. Write it down, and look at it again on a calm day.

TOOL **Where a reaction comes from** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up`

07

Write down the rulebook from home.

Finish these six lines the way your childhood home would have: “In my family, love looked like…” “When someone was upset, we…” “The jobs were split like this…” “Resting was okay when…” “Asking for help meant…” “The unforgivable thing was…” The rulebook page has room to write them. Nothing is saved except on your own device.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The rulebook from home

Nadia, on her own

Your rulebook from home

Write a few words on each line, the way the home you grew up in would have finished it. Skip any line you like. Then, for each one, ask: do I still want this rule?

1. In my family, love looked like…

Doing things. Dad fixed your bike; nobody said it.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

2. When someone was upset, we…

Went quiet and waited for it to pass.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

3. The jobs were split like this…

Mum noticed, planned and remembered. Dad did the big jobs.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

4. Resting was okay when…

Everything else was done.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften *Drop*

5. Asking for help meant…
You hadn't planned well enough.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften *Drop*

6. The unforgivable thing was…
Breaking a promise.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften Drop

A *made-up example. Names and details are invented.*
Fill in your own: The rulebook from home
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)

08

You get to choose which rules to keep.

For each line, ask: do I still want this rule? When a reaction feels bigger than the moment, try the one-minute lens check once you've settled: Where did I learn this? How old does this feel? Is it true here, with this person, now? What would the adult me choose? Later, you can swap rulebooks with someone you trust and choose shared rules on purpose.

09

The past isn't yours to change. What you carry forward is.

You couldn't control the home you grew up in, what other people did, or what you learned before you had all the facts. What is in your hands now is smaller, and stronger: which old rules you keep, how you treat yourself about them, and where you spend your energy today. That includes people. Give your time and care where they're met with care, and let one-sided effort shrink back to what

feels fair. Matching energy with energy isn't cold. It protects what you have, so you still have something to give.

The ideas, one at a time

Each idea above again, with a real-life example, words you could use and one small step. Read one and stop if you like.

1. You're not one thing

For example: A grandmother snaps when her grown-up son is late for lunch. Part is her wiring (she likes things on time). Part is an old rule ("late means you don't care"). And part is that she slept badly.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Some of this is me being tired, and some of it is an old thing. Give me a minute."

> TRY THIS:
> Next time you react strongly, ask: is this mostly wiring, something I learned, or just today?

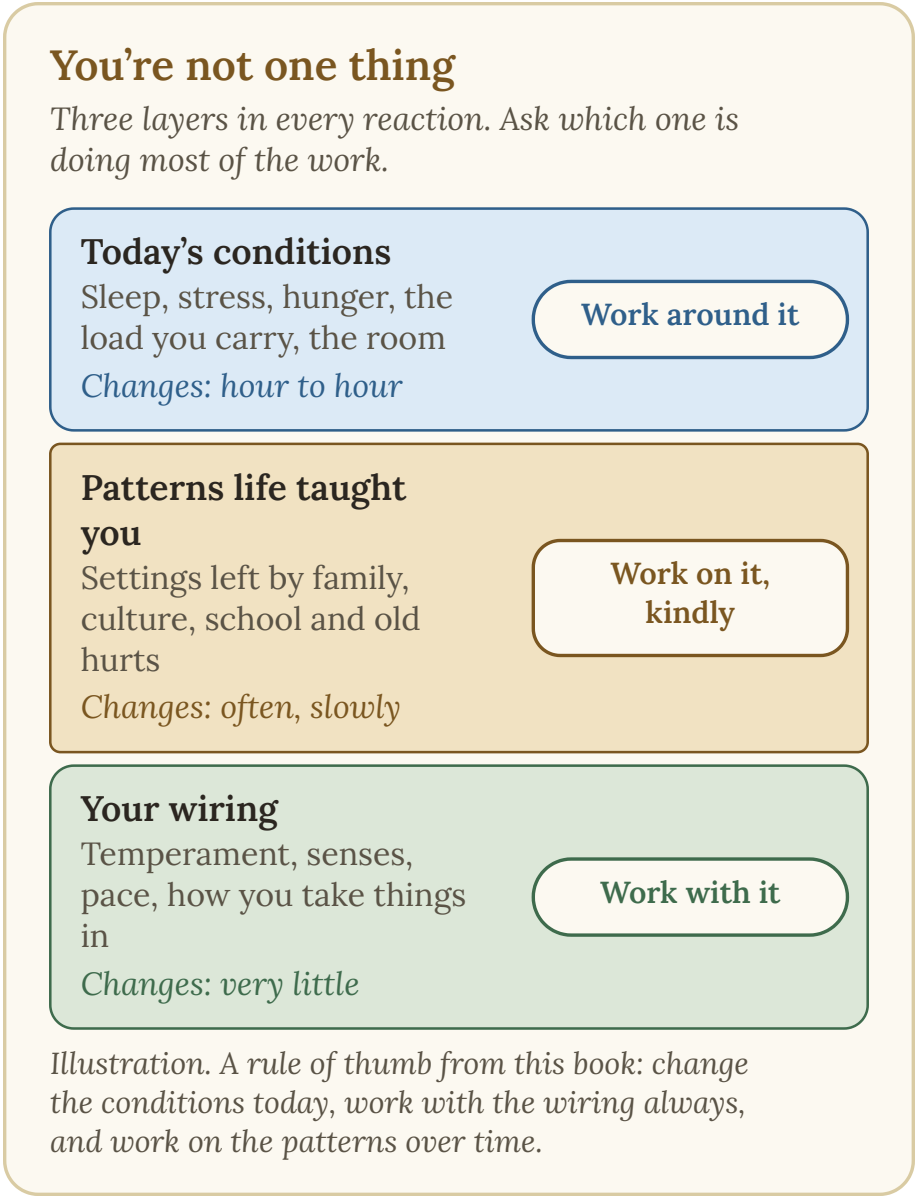


FIGURE 1 Three layers in every reaction. Each one changes at a different speed and needs a different move.

2. Your lens came from somewhere

For example: One friend grew up with big birthday parties, the other with quiet ones. A small dinner feels hurtful to one and

perfect to the other.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "In my family this was a big deal. What was it like in yours?"

> TRY THIS:
> Pick one thing you think "everyone" does. Ask one person how their family did it.

3. Each stage asks its own question

For example: Someone who moved schools four times as a teen may still feel like the outsider at every new job.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think part of me is still asking whether I belong here."

> TRY THIS:
> Read the questions above and notice which one still feels loud. That's all.

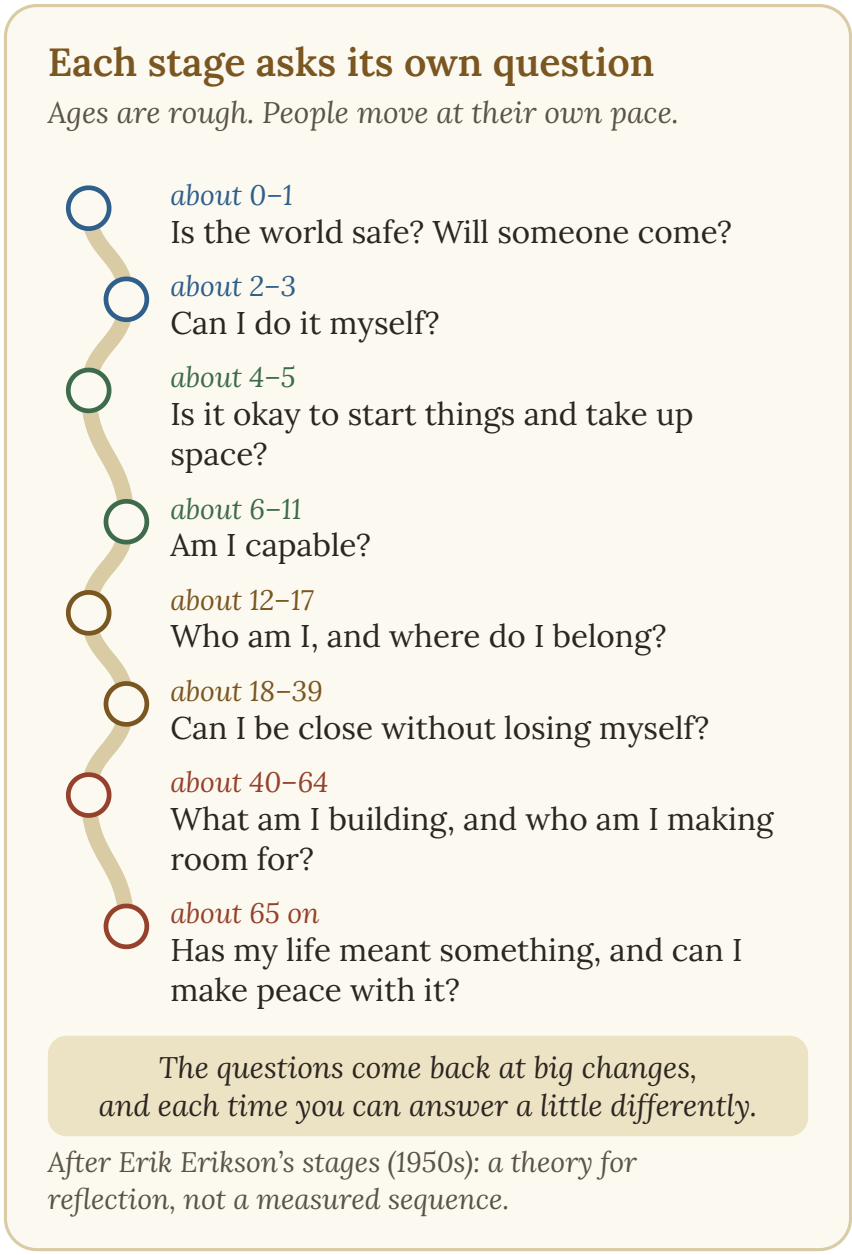


FIGURE 2 Each stage of life asks its own question. The ages are rough, and the questions come back at big changes (after Erik Erikson).

4. When something happened matters

For example: Two adult siblings remember their parents' divorce differently. One was six and remembers new routines. The other was fifteen and remembers feeling torn in half. Both are true. See Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "We were different ages when it happened. It makes sense we remember it differently."

> TRY THIS:
> Think of one big change from growing up. How old were you, and what were you trying to work out?

5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts

For example: A foster carer who learned that "my needs are a burden" finds it hard to ask for respite (a planned break while someone else cares), even when worn out. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "An old voice says I shouldn't ask. The adult me thinks asking is fair."

> TRY THIS:
> Write one old belief about yourself. Under it, write what you'd tell a friend who believed it.

6. An old rule can read other people for you

For example: A housemate leaves without saying goodbye. If quiet meant anger at home, you may think they're upset. They may just be late for a shift.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"When you went quiet earlier, I wasn't sure what it meant. Is everything okay?"

TRY THIS:

This week, when you catch yourself guessing what someone's silence means, ask instead.

7. Write down the rulebook from home

For example: Two partners from different faiths both write "holidays belong to my family," and finally see why December is hard. See Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Here's a rule I grew up with. I'm not saying it's right. I just want you to know it's there."

TRY THIS:

Finish just one of the six lines today. Leave the others for another day.

8. You get to choose which rules to keep

For example: A team leader sees that "mistakes mean I'm bad" makes them hide problems. New rule: "Mistakes are information. We fix them together."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I used to think ___. Now I'm choosing ___."

TRY THIS:

Pick one rule from your list and write the version you would like to live by.

9. What you carry forward is yours

For example: Someone living on their own always plans the meetups with one friend, who never asks back. They stop chasing, keep the door open, and see more of the friends who reply. See Always the one reaching out? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'd love to see you. Let me know when works for you."

TRY THIS:

Name one relationship where you give far more than comes back, and give a little less this month. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

TUESDAY MORNING

Two people get the same text: "Can we talk tonight?" One thinks, "Good, I like knowing ahead." The other feels their stomach drop, because in the home they grew up in, "we need to talk" meant trouble. Same words. Two different histories.



FIGURE 3 Part One in one picture: where your lens came from, how you run today, and who you are becoming. You choose what you carry forward.

You, in all your relationships

Your old rules go wherever you go, starting with how you treat yourself.

- **With yourself:** The voice you use after a mistake is often an old one.
- **With a partner, or partners:** Who notices, who plans, what quiet means. More than two of you means more than two rulebooks. See More than two partners at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).

- **With friends:** Who reaches out first, and whether asking feels okay. See Friends.
- **With family:** Old roles, like the helper or the peacemaker, switch back on at the door. See For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) and Family rifts.
- **At work:** Praised for being useful? You may say yes to everything, then resent it.
- **With housemates:** Two rulebooks about mess, noise and guests. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).
- **On your own:** After a breakup, old rules can get louder. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

Looking for your own situation? Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Ask whether a feeling is the size of this moment or older. Notice what you were praised or scolded for as a child still pulling on you. Holding an old rule in check is real, hidden effort.
- **Between you and others:** A learned rule is part of the setup, not a flaw in anyone. Say your rules out loud, and choose shared ones.

In the individual program

This part goes with Step 3 of the individual program: write the rulebook from the home you grew up in, and choose one rule you'd like to change. You can do every step on your own.

YOUR NEXT STEP:

Step 3: see where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Where your lens came from · A gentle first week · The whole book on knowing yourself (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-know-yourself)

The fields behind this part

This part draws on 4 of the author's thirteen fields (the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about) lists them all):

- **Psychology** (Read your state first): The lens you learned, the stages of growing up and the old stories we carry.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): An old alarm can go off before you've had time to think.
- **Philosophy** (Notice the quiet incentives): Plato's cave: shadows that feel like the whole world. A rule you never chose can feel like simply how things are.
- **Behavioural science** (Notice the quiet incentives): What got praised or scolded taught you what to do, and repeating something new teaches a new rule.

Two fields, one idea: Psychology + Neurobiology. How you feel and how your nervous system is running are the same moment, seen from two sides. An old alarm is both a feeling and a body state, so noticing it is the first step.

In real life

- **Partners:** "Of course it's always me." You grew up in a house where whoever noticed, did. Naming the old rule out loud, on a

calm day, turns a fight about dishes into a talk about who owns what.

- **Family:** A parent says, "We should talk." You brace, because quiet meant anger in the house you grew up in. Knowing where the alarm came from, you ask first: "Is this a good talk or a worried one?"
- **Housemates:** One housemate grew up where help was never asked for, only given. The other grew up where nothing happened unless you asked. Neither is rude. They are using two rulebooks.
- **Coworkers:** Someone who was praised mostly for being useful says yes to everything, then resents it. Seeing the old rule helps them pause before the next yes.

Common mix-ups

- **"Looking back means blaming my family."** It isn't about blame. Many of the adults who raised us were working with their own lenses too, and if that doesn't fit your story, you don't have to make it fit.
- **"If it started in childhood, I'm stuck with it."** Deeper isn't permanent. Many old patterns soften with awareness, safety and practice, and some leave a lasting sensitivity you learn to carry and explain.
- **"Every big reaction is an old wound."** Often it's just a full tank. Sort it first: Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) helps tell leftover stress from this-moment stress.
- **"My rulebook is normal, so theirs is wrong."** Each is somebody's family rule. Two rulebooks in one home are a setup to talk about, not a verdict on either person.
- **"I have to finish this before I go on."** You don't. You can read one section and stop, and come back another day.
- **"If they won't look at their rules, there's no point looking at mine."** There is. Knowing your own rules changes how you react, even if nobody else ever reads a word of this.

A note on care: This part looks back at growing up. It is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy, and it can't tell you what anyone has. Not every home felt calm or kind, so take only what is useful. If looking back feels heavy, you can stop and come back another day, or explore it with a qualified professional, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared.

TRY THIS:

Think of one “always” or “never” you felt this week.

Ask: whose voice does this sound like, and how old did I feel?

Then write one sentence the adult you would rather live by, and keep it somewhere you’ll see it.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **You’re not one thing.** A reaction comes from your wiring (it stays), the patterns life taught you (they can soften) and today’s conditions (they pass). This part is about the patterns.
- ✓ **Your lens came from somewhere:** home, school, culture, money and what you lived through. Each stage of growing up asked its own question.
- ✓ **Some old rules were learned without all the facts,** and they can read other people for you: “Whoever notices, does it.”
- ✓ **Write down the rulebook from home,** then choose which rules to keep.
- ✓ **The past isn’t yours to change.** What you carry forward is.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3 · How we see each other
How a lens shapes what you notice in other people — Understanding Each Other

Book 3 · Attachment, trust and belonging
How early trust and attachment carry into adult life — Understanding Each Other

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change
Which parts are temperament, and which can change — page 103

Book 2 · Healing after hurt
Making peace with what happened, and when to get help — Heal and Steady

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: see where your lens came from
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then-in-depth

2

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 2 · ONLINE: PART ONE · NOW

Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words

Why the same words can land differently on different days and in different people, and how to understand today's you well enough to say what helps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Today is made of two layers you can work with
2. Know how you like to be spoken to
3. Check your weather before you speak
4. Ask where this feeling is coming from
5. Plan what settles you on a calm day
6. Your needs and limits are information, not demands
7. Being wired differently is not being wrong
8. Explain yourself without over-sharing
9. Do your part, and only your part
10. The ideas, one at a time
11. You, in all your relationships
12. Inside you, and between you
13. In the individual program
14. The fields behind this part
15. In real life
16. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT:

- **Today has two layers you can work with:** your wiring, which stays (work with it), and today's conditions, which pass (work around them).
- **Check your state before a hard talk.** Weather, the three states, the load and the battery are different words for the same thing: how much room you have today.

- **If a feeling is hard to name, start with the body.** That is common, and it has a name: alexithymia.
- **Your needs and limits are information.** Plan what settles you on a calm day, and say what helps in one short sentence.
- **Different isn't wrong.** A mix-up between two different minds runs both ways, so both of you adjust a little.

SUNDAY, 7:50PM

A friend asks, "Are you okay?" You say, "Fine." The truth is you can't tell whether you're fine, tired or quietly bothered, and you couldn't explain it to yourself, let alone to them.

01

Today is made of two layers you can work with.

Your wiring is the lasting part: your temperament, your pace, your senses, how you take in words. You work *with* it, by building a setup that suits you. Today's conditions are the passing part: sleep, hunger, load, the room, the time of day. You work *around* them: eat first, sleep on it, talk tomorrow. Mixing the two up is where a lot of frustration comes from. (Then (page 7) covered the third layer, the patterns life taught you.)



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your wiring stays the same from day to day. Your weather doesn't. A one-minute check in the morning helps you tell the two apart.

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

02

Know how you like to be spoken to.

Your pace, your tone, how much you need spelled out and what silence means to you all change how words land. Wavelength (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) helps you find words for how you think, talk and listen, with a four-letter Wave Code that is a fun description, not a test. The Wiring Card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) puts how you take in words on one page you can share before a hard talk, not during one.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

Wiring Card

Ife, made on her own to give to a friend

Your card

Pick what is usually true for you. Add a few words where the buttons are not enough. Leave a line blank if it does not apply.

Who it's for

A partner Family (A *friend*) Work (a manager or coworker)

Name on the card, optional

Ife

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
In writing. One thing at a time.

I take words
Literally when it matters, tone when it is light.

Give me time to answer
A few minutes.

If I go quiet, it means
I'm thinking.

Please avoid
Long texts or many topics at once.

A request lands best as
The ask in the first sentence.

Applies more strictly when I am running low. Not a contract, and not a label. Change it when it stops being true.

A *made-up example. Names and details are invented.*

Fill in your own: Wiring Card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

03

Check your weather before you speak.

Every conversation runs through your own state first. Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) in Part Two goes deep on the stress tank, so this part only adds the self side: a one-minute reading, on your own, before you decide what a hard moment means. Today's Weather (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is the quick one, and How much are you carrying? is the fuller one, a short worksheet.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Today's Weather

Joel, on his own, after a short night

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · Someone I care for · Friends · *Mostly on my own*

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · Running on caffeine · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · *Short night* · About enough · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · A normal amount · *A lot* · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · *Food or water* · Rest · *To move* · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Pace
go gently, settle first

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for big decisions.

You said what would help is food or water and to move. Arrange that before anything else.

Overall: some room today. There is less room than usual, so spend it carefully.

If you want to send someone a line: "I'm a bit wound up today, so I'll keep replies short. It isn't about you."

A *made-up example. Names and details are invented.*
Fill in your own: Today's Weather (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

Ask where this feeling is coming from.

Name it ("tight, annoyed, a bit scared"). Then ask: is this the size of the moment, or does it feel older? Which layer is it? And what does it need right now: food, space, a heads-up, reassurance, or a real conversation later? It takes a minute, and it works best once the first wave has passed.

05

Plan what settles you on a calm day.

When you're wound up is a bad time to work out what helps. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) is a plan you make while calm: what tends to set you off, two calming steps, and

one sentence for stepping away that includes when you'll be back. It is for you, never for the other person.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: make your calm-down plan on a slow, sunny day, maybe with a cup of tea. It's much easier than making it in the middle of a storm.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

06

Your needs and limits are information, not demands.

What helps you, what matters to you and what you have left are facts about you. Said kindly, they let other people plan around you: "A heads-up helps me," "I can take this one, not that one," "I'm low today, can we talk tomorrow?" Who did what (Part B) has ready-made kind ways to say no, and Say it so it lands turns a raw reaction into a fact, a feeling and an ask.

07

Being wired differently is not being wrong.

Some people take in words, noise, change and feelings differently from what most social customs were built around. That is wiring, not a flaw to fix. You can understand it, plan around it and get support for it, if you choose. A mix-up also runs both ways: Wired Differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) shows how two differently wired people can each misread the other, with nobody at fault.

08

Explain yourself without over-sharing.

Three short sentences cover most moments. “This is how I’m wired. It won’t change, but here’s what helps.” “This is an old alarm. I’m working on it, and here’s what helps in the moment.” “Today’s a low-battery day.” You never owe anyone your history. Share the part that helps them help you, as information and not as a list of rules.

09

Do your part, and only your part.

Today you control your words, your effort, your rest, your limits and what you ask for. You don’t control someone else’s mood, reply, pace or choices, and trying to manage them drains you fast. So do your side well, then let go of theirs. And match energy with energy: meet warmth with warmth and effort with effort, and when you keep giving far more than comes back, give a little less until it balances. It protects your battery, and a protected battery is what keeps you kind.

The ideas, one at a time

Each idea above again, with a real-life example, words you could use and one small step. Read one and stop if you like.

1. Two layers you can work with

For example: A dad who works nights finds the school-run chatter unbearable at 8am. That isn’t who he is. It’s the hour. He swaps to the afternoon pick-up, and the chatter is fun again. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “It’s not you, it’s the hour. Can we talk after I’ve slept?”

TRY THIS:

Write one thing that always bothers you (probably wiring) and one that only bothers you when you're tired (conditions).

2. How you like to be spoken to

For example: A grandmother loves phone calls. Her grandson loves texts. Each thinks the other is being distant. Once they say how they like to talk, they settle on a Sunday call and texts in between.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I take things in best when ___. How about you?"

TRY THIS:

Finish the sentence "I take things in best when..." and keep it for your Wiring Card (a one-page note on how you like to be spoken to).

3. Check your weather first

For example: A long-distance couple notice their hard calls are always at the end of one partner's late shift. They move serious talks to weekend mornings. See Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm running on empty tonight. Can we pick this up tomorrow morning?"

TRY THIS:

For three mornings, describe your inner weather in one of the three sky words Today's Weather uses: clear, gusty or fogged in.

ONE STATE, MANY WORDS. The book and its tools use a few everyday pictures for one thing: how much room you have today. They are different words for the same state, not different things to measure.

- **The three states** (Part Three calls them the ladder): calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty.
- **Today's Weather** uses sky words for the same three: *clear* is calm and connected, *gusty* is revved up, and *fogged in* is running on empty. Its *pressure* (light, building or heavy) is how much you were already carrying.
- **The load**, also called the stress tank, is the score from How much are you carrying?, from 0 to 1. Higher means heavier.
- **The battery** is the other side of the load: the energy you have left. A heavy load means a low battery.

So "gusty", "revved up", "a fairly full tank" and "a low battery" can all describe the same afternoon. Use whichever words suit you.

4. Where is the feeling coming from?

For example: A coworker says, "Quick question?" and your heart races. Name it: jumpy. Older? Yes, an old boss. Layer: a pattern, plus a busy day. Need: a moment to settle.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Sure. Give me five minutes and I'll be right with you."

TRY THIS:
Next time a feeling surprises you, do just the first step: name it in two words.

When feelings are hard to name: For some people, "What are you feeling?" is a hard question most days, not just bad ones. They notice a racing heart or a heavy stomach, but can't tell if it is worry, anger or hunger. Psychologists call this *alexithymia* ("no words for feelings"). It is a trait that runs from a little to a lot, not an illness, and it is common, especially in autistic people. The feelings are there; the words come slowly. What helps: start with the body ("tight chest, skipped lunch"), choose between two words ("more tired or more annoyed?"), use the three sky words instead of feeling words, and give it time. "I'll tell you tomorrow" is a real answer.

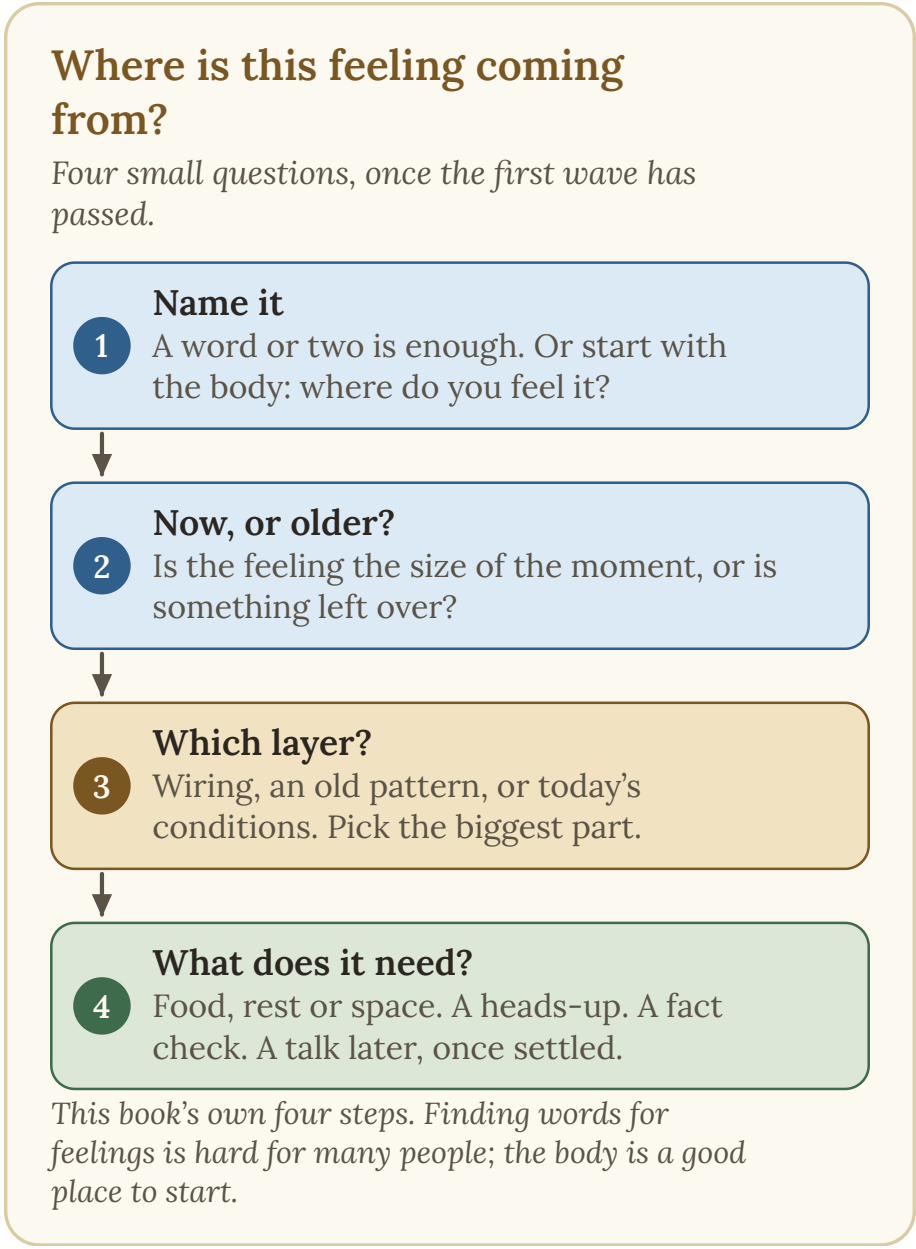


FIGURE 4 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected. Do it once the first wave has passed.

5. Plan what settles you

For example: A teenager makes a plan with herself. When a row with her mum heats up, she says, "I need ten minutes in my room, then I'll come back." And she comes back.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm too wound up to listen well. I need twenty minutes, then I'll come back."

> TRY THIS:
> On a calm day, write your one stepping-away sentence, including when you'll be back.

6. Needs are information

For example: In a home with three partners, Quinn needs an hour alone after work. Said once, kindly, it becomes part of the plan instead of a mystery. See More than two partners at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I can do ___. I can't do ___ this week. Could we ___ instead?"

> TRY THIS:
> Write one need you've never said out loud. Practise saying it as a fact, not an apology.

7. Different isn't wrong

For example: A woman with ADHD keeps forgetting plans with a friend. Instead of "I'm hopeless," she says what helps: "If you text me the day before, I'll be there." See Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"My brain works a bit differently. Here's what helps me get it right."

A mix-up runs both ways: When an autistic and a non-autistic person misread each other, it is easy to blame the autistic person. The *double empathy problem*, named by the autistic researcher Damian Milton, is the idea that the gap runs both ways: each person reads the other through their own way of communicating, and each finds the other hard to read. In one study, a story passed along a chain of autistic people kept as much detail as one passed along non-autistic people; mixed chains lost detail faster. So nobody is the broken one. Ask "Where did we lose each other?" and both adjust a little.

TRY THIS:

Name one setting where you work best (quiet, written down, early, with music) and give yourself it once this week.

8. Explain, without over-sharing

For example: A man with a long-term illness tells a new friend, "Some days I have less energy. If I cancel, it isn't about you." He shares what helps, not his medical history. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Today's a low-battery day. It isn't about you."

TRY THIS:

Pick one of the three short sentences above and say it out loud once, on your own.

9. Your part, and only your part

For example: A grown-up daughter keeps trying to stop her father worrying about her. She can't. She can send a short "Home safe" text after long drives, then let his worry be his. See For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I can't stop you worrying, but I can text when I'm home."

TRY THIS:

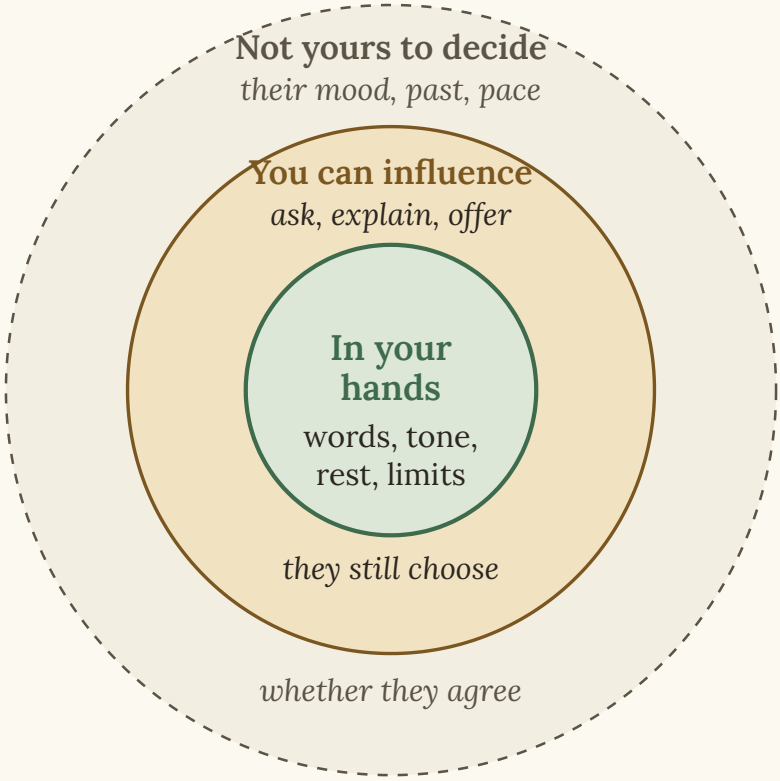
Write one thing you keep trying to control that isn't yours. Next to it, write one thing that is. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

FRIDAY, 6:40PM

"Surprise! I booked us dinner with my cousins tonight." They meant it as a gift. You felt your chest tighten and heard yourself say "Great" in a flat voice. Later you wonder: is that just me, is it something from years ago, or am I simply wiped out after this week? Probably a bit of all three.

Your circle of control

Spend your energy from the middle out.



Most exhaustion comes from pouring energy into the outer ring.

Illustration.

FIGURE 5 Your circle of control. Spend your energy from the middle out; most exhaustion comes from pouring it into the outer ring.

You, in all your relationships

Your wiring and your weather come with you everywhere, starting with how you treat yourself on a hard day.

- **With yourself:** Noticing "I'm low today" before you decide "I'm failing."
- **With partners:** A heads-up, a quiet hour, a better time to talk. Every partner, and every extra partner, has a wiring of their own.
- **With friends and family:** How you like to keep in touch, and how much you can give this month. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **At work:** An agenda ahead, a written plan, a minute before you answer.
- **With housemates:** Noise, light and quiet time. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).
- **On your own:** Building a week that suits how you're built. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

Find your own situation in help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Check your state and know your wiring before you judge a reaction. Count the hidden effort, like masking (hiding or toning down how you naturally are, to fit in) or holding an old alarm down, as real load.
- **Between you and others:** Change the setup, not the person. Tell people what helps, tune how you send and receive, and treat a mismatch as tuning, not a moral failing.

In the individual program

This part goes with Steps 1, 2, 4 and 5 of the individual program: check your battery, get to know your wiring, plan what settles you, and find words for what you feel.

YOUR NEXT STEP:

Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 2: your wiring · Step 4: what settles you · Step 5: find the words · The whole book on knowing yourself (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-know-yourself)

The fields behind this part

This part draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about) lists them all):

- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): How you take words in and send them out, and what helps you feel understood.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): Your nervous system's state comes before your words, and wiring is part of how you are built.
- **Philosophy** (Tune how you send and receive): Your honesty, your ask and your tone are up to you. The other person's answer is up to them.
- **Behavioural science** (Read your state first): Try small routines on calm days, like a one-minute reading and a sentence you keep ready.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, words second. Decide on a calm day what settles you.

- **Economics** (See the whole load): Managing yourself costs effort that doesn't show, and it counts as part of the load.

Two fields, one idea: Philosophy + Neurobiology. If getting revved up or shutting down is a body doing its job, it isn't a character flaw. That changes what blame means, including the blame you aim at yourself.

In real life

- **Partners:** Sam knows surprise plans make their chest tighten, and says so on a calm day: "A heads-up helps me. It isn't about you." Now their partner knows what to try.
- **Family:** You need a quiet half hour after a long visit. You say so before you go: "I'll be good company after a short rest." It sounds like a plan, not a retreat.
- **Housemates:** One housemate needs an hour of quiet after work to recover. The other hears it as being shut out. A one-line note settles it: "Quiet until seven isn't about you. I'm back after."
- **Coworkers:** Someone thinks best with the agenda a day ahead. They say it once, as how they work and not as an apology: "Could the agenda come the day before?"

Common mix-ups

- **"Knowing myself means finding the right label."** It's about what helps, not a name. The three layers and a Wave Code are everyday words, not a diagnosis.
- **"'That's just how I am' ends the talk."** It may be true, especially for wiring. It works better as a start: "This is how I'm wired, and here's what helps."
- **"If I tell people how I'm wired, they have to manage me."** Telling them helps their words land. You still do your part, and they still have their own needs.
- **"I'm fine" means I'm fine.** Sometimes. It can also mean you've been tired for so long you stopped noticing. A quick reading each week shows a baseline you've got used to.
- **"Looking at myself is selfish."** Every conversation runs through your own state. Knowing it is part of being easier to talk with.
- **"If I need something, I have to justify it."** You don't. "A heads-up helps me" is enough. A reason is a kindness you can offer, not a fee you owe.

A note on care: This part is general education. It isn't a diagnosis, a test or treatment, and it can't tell you whether you're autistic, have ADHD or anything else, or what anyone else has. If you'd like to understand yourself more deeply, a qualified professional can help, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you try needs to be shared. If talking about any of this with someone ever feels unsafe, or you feel you can't say no, stop and talk with a trained counselor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counseling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

TRY THIS:

Pick one reaction you had this week, and write one line for each layer.

"My wiring part is…" "The older part is…" "Today's part was…"

Then take a one-minute reading of your weather, and write one sentence about what helps you, in your own words. Keep it to yourself for a few days.

When it feels right, share that one sentence with one person, on a calm day.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Today has two layers you can work with:** your wiring, which stays (work with it), and today's conditions, which pass (work around them).
- ✓ **Check your state before a hard talk.** Weather, the three states, the load and the battery are different words for the same thing: how much room you have today.
- ✓ **If a feeling is hard to name, start with the body.** That is common, and it has a name: alexithymia.
- ✓ **Your needs and limits are information.** Plan what settles you on a calm day, and say what helps in one short sentence.
- ✓ **Different isn't wrong.** A mix-up between two different minds runs both ways, so both of you adjust a little.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently page 119
Wiring differences: autism, ADHD and the senses

Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system Heal and Steady
Why your weather changes how you hear things

Book 4 · Full tanks and different angles Share the Load
The stress tank, used between two people

Book 4 · Two kinds of fair Share the Load
What fair means when you share the work

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

How much are you carrying? A quick stress check
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth

3

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 3 · ONLINE: PART ONE · NEXT

Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming

You aren't finished, and some of who you become is up to you. This part is about choosing a direction, and building small steps that still work on a tired day.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Start with what matters to you
2. Pick one small goal, in plain words
3. Name what gets in the way
4. Make the step tiny, and repeatable
5. Decide ahead with a simple if-then
6. Ask for support, as information
7. Look back kindly once a month
8. Kindness to yourself is part of the plan
9. Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back
10. The ideas, one at a time
11. You, in all your relationships
12. Inside you, and between you
13. In the individual program
14. The fields behind this part
15. In real life
16. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT:

- **Start with what matters to you,** in two or three plain words, then pick one small goal you can do.
- **Make the step tiny and decide ahead:** "If it's after dinner, then I put my shoes on."
- **Ask for support as information,** and look back kindly once a month.
- **A missed day is information about the plan,** not a verdict on you. Change the plan.

- **Set goals inside your circle,** and spend your energy where it comes back.

WEDNESDAY, 9:10PM

You meant to start walking after dinner. You meant to last week, too. Tonight you're tired, the shoes are by the door, and you tell yourself you'll begin on Monday.

01

Start with what matters to you.

A goal built on someone else's idea of success is hard to keep up. Before you pick anything, ask: what do I want my days to be like? Write two or three plain words, like calm, close to my family, steady or creative. They are a direction, not a score. Wavelength (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) can help you notice what fills you up and what drains you.

02

Pick one small goal, in plain words.

Just one. Say it as something you will do, not something you hope will happen: "Walk for ten minutes after dinner," not "get healthier." Your own actions are up to you. How other people respond, and how things turn out, are not.

03

Name what gets in the way.

Use what you learned in Then (page 7) and Now (page 27). Is it your wiring (a plan that ignores how you're built is built for someone else)? An old rule ("rest has to be earned")? Or today's conditions (a tired evening)? Then change the arrangement, never yourself: move the step to the morning, not the person to a better version.

04

Make the step tiny, and repeatable.

Small enough to survive your worst week. “Put my shoes on” counts. Tie it to something you already do, and do it often. This is the same idea as the 90-second daily check-in in Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1-in-depth) of Part Two: small and often beats big and rare. Start in 10 minutes (spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes) shows how small a whole path can be.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: tiny steps count, even the wobbly ones! If you like a game, there’s one where each small kind act moves the ball up the field.

TOOL **Calm football game for small kind acts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

05

Decide ahead with a simple if-then.

“If it’s after dinner, then I put my shoes on.” Deciding ahead means one less decision on a tired day, the same idea as the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11), which you make while calm. If a plan isn’t working, that’s information about the plan, not about you. Change the plan.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

The Calm-Down Kit, just for me

Nell, on her own

The Calm-Down Kit

Your name
Nell

Date
11 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
A long message from my sister late at night	*Tight chest, typing fast*
Plans changed with no warning	*Jaw, hot face*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Walking it out

Second, if the first isn't available
Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm at capacity. I'm going to step away for twenty minutes, and I'll answer properly after that.

My pause plan (yours to share, if you like)

My pause word or signal
"Back in a bit"

The shortest break I take
20 minutes

How I set the time to come back
I text a time, the same day

The first sentence when I come back
"Thanks for waiting. I can think straight now."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
9:40 pm	*Walking it out*	*Still hot*
10:05 pm	*Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: pick things back up, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Reply to my sister's message, one line

If you put it off: when you'll pick it back up
Tomorrow after lunch

☑ I'm going with this

A made-up example. Names and details are invented.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (Just me)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

06

Ask for support, as information.

Tell one person what you're trying and what would help: "I'm trying to walk after dinner. Could you ask me about it on Sunday?" It isn't a demand, they can say no, and you don't need their agreement to start. Some goals are better with a qualified professional, and asking for one is a sensible step, if and when you want that.

07

Look back kindly once a month.

It mirrors Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5) of Part Two, pointed at yourself. Once a month, take ten minutes: what went well? What kept slipping? Was the gap in the plan, in how much you have right now, or just a one-off week? You don't add up old misses. You only ask what to try next month.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your monthly look is the solo version of the look-back in Chapter V. Borrow its two questions if you like: what kept slipping, and what would have made it easier?

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

08

Kindness to yourself is part of the plan.

A plan that needs you to be harsh with yourself is built on a "second arrow": the first arrow is the slip itself, and the second is the telling-off you give yourself afterwards, which hurts more and helps less. A missed day is information. Rest is part of the plan, not a prize for finishing. You can shrink a goal, change it or drop it. Nothing here is required, and you can stop any time.

09

Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

A goal that depends on someone else changing is a wish. Shape each goal around what you can do: "I'll ask once, kindly, by Friday," not "They'll start helping." Then budget your energy like the limited thing it is. Put more into the people and plans that give back, and less into the ones that only take. That isn't selfish. It's

how you keep going long enough to reach the goal, and still have something left to give.

The ideas, one at a time

Each idea above again, with a real-life example, words you could use and one small step. Read one and stop if you like.

1. Start with what matters

For example: After their youngest leaves home, a couple each write two words. Hers are "useful, outdoors." His are "calm, curious." Suddenly it makes sense that she wants to volunteer and he wants the garden. See Kids grown and gone (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "What I want my days to feel like is ___."

> TRY THIS:
> Write two plain words for what matters to you right now. Pencil is fine. You can change them.

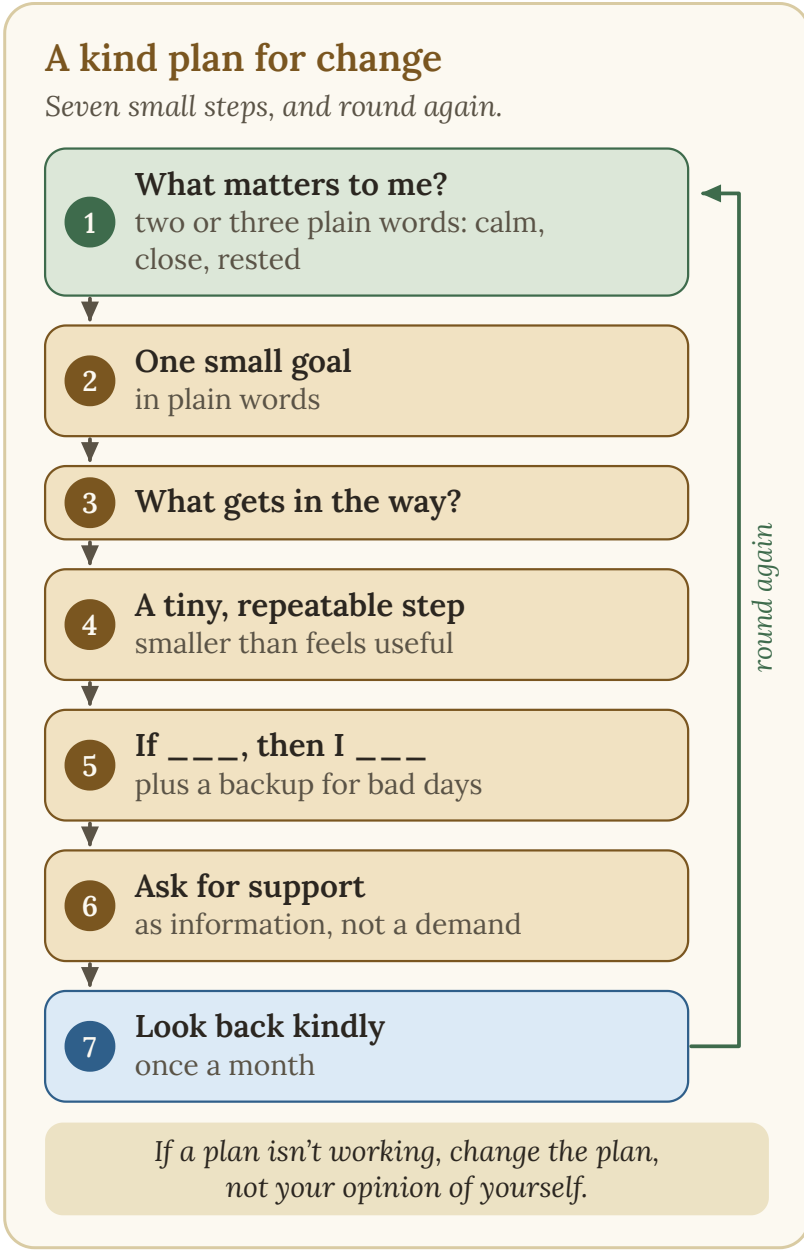


FIGURE 6 A kind plan for change in seven small steps. If the plan isn't working, change the plan, not your opinion of yourself.

2. One small goal, in plain words

For example: A student in a shared dorm room wants "to be less messy." As an action, it becomes "Put my clothes in the basket before bed." See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "My one goal this month is ___."

> TRY THIS:
> Rewrite one wish as something you will do, starting with "I will..."

3. What gets in the way

For example: A shift worker keeps missing his evening run. It isn't laziness. His rota (his work timetable) changes every week. He ties the run to "my first day off" instead of "evenings." See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "It's not that I don't care. The setup doesn't fit yet."

> TRY THIS:
> Pick one thing that keeps slipping. Ask: is it my wiring, an old rule, or today's conditions?

4. Tiny and repeatable

For example: Someone on their own after a breakup wants to "get back out there." The tiny step: one message to one friend every Sunday. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm starting really small, on purpose."

TRY THIS:

Shrink your step until it takes less than two minutes.

5. Decide ahead

For example: A separated parent wants calmer handovers. Her if-then: "If I pull up outside, then I take three slow breaths before I get out of the car." See Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"If ___ happens, then I'll ___."

TRY THIS:

Write one if-then. Pick a cue that happens every day, like the kettle, the front door or brushing your teeth.

6. Ask for support

For example: A woman caring for her husband after a stroke asks her brother, "Could you sit with him on Thursday afternoons so I can swim?" Because it is specific, it is easy to say yes or no. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm trying ___. Would you be up for ___? It's fine to say no."

TRY THIS:

Name one person and one small, specific thing they could do. (If someone uses your goals to check up on you or control you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

7. Look back kindly

For example: A grandmother raising her two grandchildren looks back on the month. Bedtime is working. Homework isn't. Next month she tries homework at the kitchen table straight after a snack. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What went well, what kept slipping, and what will I try next?"

TRY THIS:

Put ten minutes in your calendar for the first of next month.

8. Kindness is part of the plan

For example: A sixteen-year-old sets a goal to revise every night, misses three nights and says, "I'm useless." His grandmother asks, "What would you tell your best friend?" He shrinks the goal to twenty minutes.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"That was a missed day, not a missed life."

TRY THIS:

Next time you miss a step, say one sentence to yourself that you would say to a friend.

9. Inside your circle

For example: You'd like your adult sister to call more. That goal sits outside your circle. Inside it: "I'll call on the first Sunday of each month, and tell her I'd love her to call too." See Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'd love it if ___. Either way, I'll ___."

TRY THIS:

Rewrite one goal that depends on someone else, so the next step is yours.

THE FIRST OF THE MONTH

You open your notes. Of the four small things you tried, two stuck and two quietly stopped. Nothing went wrong. You just know now which two need a different setup.

You, in all your relationships

A goal for yourself often touches the people around you. Small steps work everywhere.

- **With yourself:** Rest, health, a hobby you dropped, a kinder inner voice.
- **With partners:** One small habit you offer, not one you demand. See Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together).
- **With friends:** One message a week. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).

- **With family:** A regular call, a visit you can keep up, or a first step after years apart. See Reaching out.
- **At work:** One comment per meeting, one clear handover note.
- **With money:** One small saving habit you control. See Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).
- **On your own:** A week that suits you. See On my own.

Find your own situation in help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Treat your own routines as a setup you can adjust, not a character test. Notice the defaults and cues that steer you, and let the easy path be the one you want. Pick the step for the energy you really have.
- **Between you and others:** Say what you're trying and what would help, as information. Let people's answers be theirs, and fix the setup, not the person.

In the individual program

This part goes with the end of the individual program: a gentle first week, then the Individual package, which turns your workpapers into a report written just for you.

YOUR NEXT STEP:

A gentle first week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · The Individual package and your report · All six steps · The whole book on knowing yourself (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-know-yourself)

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

The self path, step by step

Sam, on their own, two weeks in

The path, step by step

Step	Where it's at
Check your battery	*Done ✓*
Get to know your wiring	*Done ✓*
See where your lens came from	*Done ✓*
Plan what settles you	Not yet
Find words for what you feel	Not yet
Practice kind ways to say no	Not yet

Come back gently, once a week

Pick a day and a time, and add a ten-minute reminder to your own calendar. It repeats every week and just says "10 minutes for me".

Day	Time
Sunday	*7:30 pm*

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The next step is Plan what settles you: the Calm-Down Kit. Three steps done is three steps done; the rest will still be here next week.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented.

Fill in your own: The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path)

The fields behind this part

This part draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about) lists them all):

- **Behavioural science** (Notice the quiet incentives): Habits beat willpower, especially when you're tired. Cues and defaults steer us more than intentions do.
- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): What matters to you, and what you tell yourself when a day goes wrong.
- **Philosophy** (Tune how you send and receive): What Is Up to Us, and Aristotle's idea that we become what we repeatedly do.
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): A small, regular review catches problems while they are small.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): Attention is limited, so one small goal beats five big ones.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Small repeated acts are rhythms, and rest is part of the rhythm.

Two fields, one idea: Philosophy + Behavioural science. Aristotle thought we become what we repeatedly do. Character, like a habit, is built by small acts, not by one big decision.

In real life

- **Partners:** One partner wants calmer evenings. They pick one small step, no phones at the table for ten minutes, and say so: "I'm trying this. Would you try it with me?" The other can say yes, not yet or no.
- **Family:** You'd like to be in touch with a sibling more. "If it's Sunday after lunch, then I call for ten minutes" is easier to keep than "I should call more."

- **Housemates:** You want the kitchen to stay clear. Your part is a setup, not willpower: "If I make a drink, then I wash the cup before I sit down."
- **Coworkers:** You'd like to speak up more in meetings. One comment per meeting, written down beforehand from the agenda, is a goal you can actually do.

Common mix-ups

- **"A goal has to be big to count."** Small and repeatable is what survives a bad week. Big goals are often just many small ones.
- **"If I miss a day, I've failed."** A missed day tells you about the plan. Ask what got in the way, then adjust the setup.
- **"If I know myself, I should be able to change anything."** Wiring stays. The aim is a goal that fits how you're built, not a different you.
- **"Asking for support means I couldn't manage alone."** It's information that helps others help. People who ask are using the setup well.
- **"A monthly look-back means grading myself."** It's a look, not a trial. It never adds up old misses.
- **"I'll start on Monday."** A fresh start can help, but today's tiny version counts too. Put your shoes on now.

A note on care: This part is general education. It isn't therapy, coaching or medical advice, and it can't promise any result. Goals about your health, money, work or a hard stretch in life may deserve a qualified professional, and there's no shame in asking for one. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared. If a goal ever starts to feel like a weight, you can shrink it or put it down.

TRY THIS:

Write two plain words for what matters to you right now.

Write one small goal as something you will do. Then the tiniest first step, and one if-then: "If ___, then I ___."

Put a ten-minute look-back on the calendar for a month from now. At that look-back, ask: what went well, what kept slipping, and what will I try next?

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Start with what matters to you,** in two or three plain words, then pick one small goal you can do.
- ✓ **Make the step tiny and decide ahead:** "If it's after dinner, then I put my shoes on."
- ✓ **Ask for support as information,** and look back kindly once a month.
- ✓ **A missed day is information about the plan,** not a verdict on you. Change the plan.
- ✓ **Set goals inside your circle,** and spend your energy where it comes back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2 · Values, meaning and a good life
Finding out what matters to you — Heal and Steady

Book 2 · Habits and change
Why tiny steps and if-then plans work — Heal and Steady

Book 4 · The monthly look-back
The same monthly look, done together — Share the Load

Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
A kinder inner voice when a step slips — page 85

PUT IT TO USE

The self path, step by step
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

The Calm-Down Kit: a plan for heated moments
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next-in-depth

4

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry. For anyone: on your own, at home, with friends, at work or out in the world.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **A feeling is a signal,** not a verdict. It says "something here matters to me." It doesn't say what to do.
- **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often comes before the word for it.
- **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.

- **Feeling it isn't doing it.** You can let a feeling be there and still choose what you do next.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Today's Weather and the daily check-in** (Part One, Now (page 27); Part Two, Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1)) ask for one word about how you are. Naming a feeling turns its volume down a little, and a daily word catches feelings while they are still small. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **Say it so it lands** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) asks for a feeling, not a verdict. "I felt let down" is easier to hear than "you never care." Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

A message from your manager: "Got a minute tomorrow?" Your stomach drops. By the time you get home you have snapped at the cat, skipped dinner and replayed every mistake from the last month. Nobody has said anything bad. Your body heard "trouble" before you had a single clear thought.

This part of the book is about how people work: you, and everyone around you. We start with feelings, because they are under almost everything else. How we talk, how we see each other and how we handle stress all run through them. This chapter teaches how feelings work first. What to do with them comes second.

01

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear says "something might be a danger." Anger says "something seems unfair, or in my way." Sadness says "I lost something that mattered." A signal is worth listening to. But it can be wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm can go off for burnt toast.

For example: You feel jealous when a friend makes a new close friend. The jealousy isn't proof that you're a bad person, or that your friend is leaving. It is a signal that the friendship matters to you.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

TRY THIS:
Next time a strong feeling arrives, finish this sentence: "This feeling is trying to protect…"

02

Feelings start in the body.

Often your body reacts before your mind has a word: a racing heart, a hot face, a heavy chest, a knot in the stomach. Your brain then tries to make sense of it. That's why being hungry, tired or in pain can feel a lot like being upset. The body is sending a strong signal, and the mind guesses what it means.

For example: A teenager comes home "furious" at their parent over nothing much. After a sandwich and a sit-down, the fury is mostly gone. Some of it was hunger wearing anger's coat.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

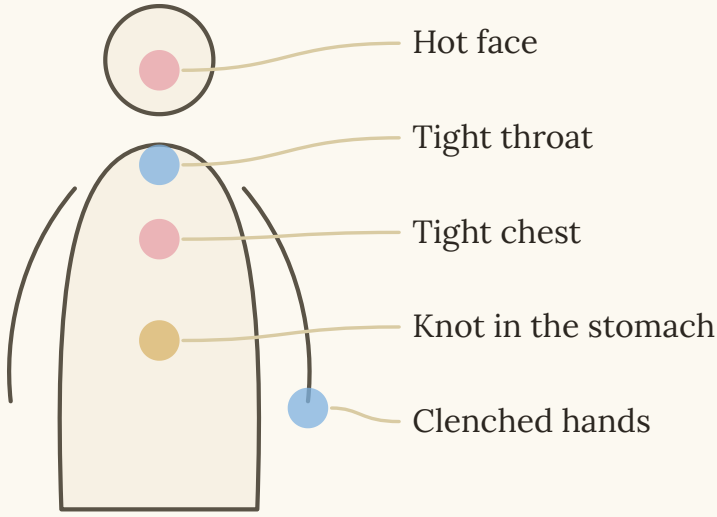
"Where is this in my body?" "Am I hungry, tired, cold or sore right now?"

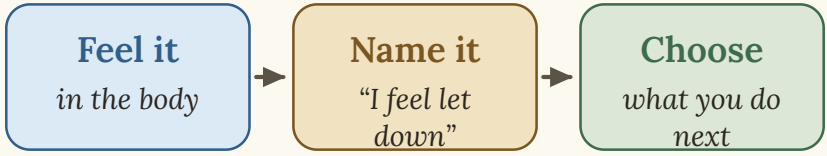
TRY THIS:

Three times today, pause and ask: "What does my body feel like right now?" Just notice. No need to change anything.

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict

It often shows up in the body before it has a word.





It says: something here matters to me.
It doesn't say what to do.

Illustration. Everyone's body signals are a little different; these are common ones, not a medical map.

FIGURE 7 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first; naming it helps you choose what to do next.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

Today's Weather

Esme, 29, at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager

---

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers* · Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Talk window
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Esme ate something, then rang her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.

Fill in your own: Today's Weather (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

03

Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down a little. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's

alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so you can see it, talk about it and decide what to do.

For example: Two housemates are tense all evening. One finally says, "I think I'm embarrassed about the noise complaint, and I've been acting cross." The other relaxes. Now they know what's in the room.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think what I'm feeling is…" "I'm not sure what this is yet. Maybe worried?"

> TRY THIS:
> Once a day, name one feeling out loud or on paper. A guess is fine. "Something like sad" still counts.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won't come, weather words often will. Pick "foggy" or "stormy" and start from there.

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

More words, better tools.

"Bad" is a very blunt word. "Disappointed," "left out," "overwhelmed" and "ashamed" each point to something different, and each needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don't need fancy words. You can use numbers, colours or body words too.

For example: A dad tells his partner, "I feel bad about my mum." They talk in circles. Then he says, "Actually, I feel guilty that I

haven't visited, and scared she's getting worse." Now the talk has somewhere to go.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"On a scale of one to ten, I'm about a six." "It's less angry and more… let down." "It feels heavy, like a grey day."

TRY THIS:
When you notice "bad," try for one more exact word. When you notice "fine," try for one more honest one.

05

Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn't always the first one you felt. Anger is often a cover for hurt or fear, because anger feels stronger and safer. And we often have feelings about our feelings: ashamed of being sad, scared of being angry. That second layer can hurt more than the first.

For example: A grandmother is short with her daughter after the grandkids' visit is cancelled. Under the shortness is hurt. Under the hurt is a fear: "Am I still needed?"

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"What might be under this one?" "It's okay to feel this. I don't also have to feel bad for feeling it."

TRY THIS:
Next time you feel angry, ask gently: "Is there hurt or worry underneath?" You don't have to say it. Just look.

06

Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise, peak and settle if you don't keep feeding them. Moods are different. They are like weather (in plain words: a background feeling that lasts hours or days) that colours everything, often without you noticing. A grey mood can make a small thing feel huge, and a good mood can make the same thing feel like nothing.

For example: A woman living alone has a bad morning and decides "my whole life is going nowhere." By evening, after a walk and a call with her sister, the same life looks ordinary and okay. The facts didn't change. Her weather did.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This is a wave. It will peak and pass." "Is this a feeling about now, or a mood colouring everything?"

TRY THIS:
Don't make big decisions at the top of a wave. Write the decision down, and look at it again tomorrow.

07

Feelings spread between people.

We pick up each other's feelings, often without noticing: a tense voice, a sigh, a slammed door. That's part of how people bond. It also means stress can move round a home or a team like a cold. You can care about someone's feeling without catching all of it.

For example: A team leader comes into a meeting rushed and anxious. Within ten minutes the whole team feels behind. The next week, she takes two slow breaths at the door first. The meeting feels different.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Is this feeling mine, or did I pick it up?" "I can stay beside their storm without standing in the middle of it."

TRY THIS:

Notice who you tend to "catch" feelings from. Before your next talk with them, settle yourself for one minute first.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: good moods are catching too! Tail wags definitely are. Want a small way to share one?

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

08

If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Many people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private: "Don't make a fuss," "Big boys don't cry," "We don't talk about that." This is common for men and for older people, and in some cultures it is a sign of respect and strength.

It isn't a flaw. And it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely say a feeling show it every day by doing: fixing the tap, driving someone to hospital, turning up. Caring by doing is real caring. Words can be added slowly, at your own pace, a few at a time.

For example: A retired builder whose wife has died has never talked about feelings in his life. At his grandson's football match, he finally says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder. Nothing else needs to be said.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

TRY THIS:

Pick one sentence above and say it once this week, to one person, or even just out loud on your own. Short is fine. A text counts. So does writing it down.

09

Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually comes with an urge: to shout, run, hide, check, fix or text. The feeling isn't a choice. What you do with the urge is more of one. Pushing a feeling down tends to make it come back stronger, and acting on every urge can hurt people. The middle path is: let the feeling be there, and choose the action.

For example: A father feels a hot rush of anger when his son breaks a window with a ball. He says, "I'm too cross to talk right now. Let's sort this out in ten minutes." The anger was real. The shouting didn't happen.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm feeling a lot right now. I'm going to take a minute before I answer." "I want to reply when I'm calmer."

TRY THIS:

Pick one urge you often act on too fast, like sending a sharp text. Make a rule: wait ten minutes first.

FRIDAY, 9:05AM

You notice the knot in your stomach again. This time you name it: "I'm scared I'm in trouble." You remember it's a signal, not a verdict, and you ask your manager straight away: "Is today's chat about something I should worry about?" "Oh no, it's about the summer rota." The knot loosens. The feeling was real. The story it told was not.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** No one else is there to notice for you, so a daily one-word check-in with yourself matters more. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).
- **With a partner:** "What are you feeling?" can sound like a test. "Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?" is easier to answer.
- **With friends:** A friend going quiet may be feeling low, not cross with you. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Parents and children:** Children learn feeling words from us. Naming your own ("I'm frustrated, so I'm taking a breath") teaches more than any lesson. See For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents).
- **At work:** Feelings don't stay at home. A short "I'm a bit flat today, not upset with anyone" can stop a team guessing. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **If you show love by doing:** Fixing, driving, cooking and turning up are love. If someone close shows care that way, you can thank them for it in words: "I noticed you cleared the drive. Thank you."

- **With strangers:** The rude person in the queue may be scared, in pain or grieving. You can't know. You can choose not to catch it.

Common mix-ups

- **"Some feelings are bad."** Feelings aren't good or bad. Some are painful, and some actions are harmful. The feeling itself is information.
- **"If I feel it, it must be true."** Feeling stupid doesn't make you stupid. A feeling is a signal to check, not a fact.
- **"Letting it out always helps."** Shouting or hitting a pillow tends to keep anger going. Naming it, moving, or talking it through calmly helps more.
- **"Calm people don't feel much."** Many calm people feel a lot. They have just practised letting feelings be there without acting on every one.
- **"I should be able to name it straight away."** Many people find feelings hard to name, and some find it very hard. That's a difference, not a failing. Body words, numbers and colours count.
- **"Their face tells me what they feel."** Faces are a poor guide. People show the same feeling in different ways. Asking is kinder and more accurate than guessing.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Ask, don't assign.** "You're angry" can feel like a label. "You seem upset. Am I reading that right?" leaves room for them to correct you.

- **Make the feeling make sense.** "Of course you're upset, that was a lot" helps more than advice. You can make sense of a feeling without agreeing with every action.
- **Offer choices.** "Do you want ideas, or just someone to listen?" Many people only want the second.
- **Accept other ways of saying it.** Some people find words hard. A number, a text, a drawing or "I'm at a seven" is a real answer.
- **Don't make their feeling about you.** If their sadness makes you anxious, settle yourself first, so they don't have to look after your feelings too.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "That sounds really hard." "Do you want to talk, or would company help more?" "You don't have to find the right word. A number is fine."

When to get more help

Everyone has hard days and big feelings. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or another trained professional if:

- a low, numb, anxious or angry feeling stays most days for two weeks or more;
- feelings are stopping you from sleeping, eating, working or seeing people;
- you are using alcohol, drugs or other things to stop feeling;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that's happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line straight away. You deserve help today.

If you feel afraid of someone you live with or are close to, that fear is an important signal. It is not something to "manage" on your

own. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy. It can't know your situation.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Today's Weather (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself): how you tend to feel and react, and why.
- The library: what emotions are (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), naming feelings, emotional granularity, when feelings are hard to name, emotional contagion and sensing your body (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress).

More for your situation

- Next in Part Three: Stress and the nervous system (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress)
- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 27)

- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) and Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens: when feelings get loud (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- For caregivers: resentment and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A feeling is a signal,** not a verdict. It says "something here matters to me." It doesn't say what to do.
- ✓ **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often comes before the word for it.
- ✓ **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- ✓ **Feeling it isn't doing it.** You can let a feeling be there and still choose what you do next.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Reading your own weather day to day
page 27

Book 4 · Full tanks and different angles
Feelings when a stress tank is full
Share the Load

Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system
What the body does under pressure
Heal and Steady

Book 2 · Anger
One feeling up close
Heal and Steady

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Today's Weather
A short, private daily check of your mood and state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings-in-depth

5

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 5 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 7

Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame is different from guilt, and how being kind to yourself makes it easier, not harder, to grow.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Your worth isn't a score.** It doesn't rise and fall with each day's results.
- **Guilt and shame are different.** Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right.
- **Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.** Being kind to yourself after a mistake makes it easier to own it and grow.

- **Worth is something we can give.** How we treat each other teaches people what they are worth.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **"Writing it down isn't keeping score"** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface)) and **"It judges the setup, never a person"** (Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2)) matter because shame makes people hide and defend. Tools that measure the setup, not anyone's worth, keep shame out of the room. Big idea: *fix the setup, not the person.*
- **"Covering is kind. Say it out loud"** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) is the everyday version of owning a slip without drowning in it.

THURSDAY, 11:20PM

You sent the wrong file to the whole team. Someone noticed, fixed it, and said "no worries." Hours later you are still awake, replaying it. The voice in your head isn't saying "that was a mistake." It's saying "you're useless. They all know it now."

This chapter is for anyone: on your own, at home, with friends, at work or in your community. It teaches how self-worth and shame work first, then what you can do. Nothing here is a diagnosis. Take what helps and leave the rest.

01

Your worth isn't a score.

Many of us carry a quiet scoreboard: I'm worth something when I'm useful, liked, slim, busy, top of the class or never a bother. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth." The trouble is that any score can drop. If your worth rises and falls with each day's results, every bad day feels like a verdict on you.

For example: A retired teacher feels lost since she stopped working. She's fine. But for forty years, "I'm needed" was how she knew she mattered.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Today went badly. That's about today, not about my worth." "I matter on days I achieve nothing."

> TRY THIS:
> Finish the line "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times. Those are your scores. Just notice them.

02

Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points towards fixing it: saying sorry, making it right. Shame is about who you are, and that feels impossible to fix. So shame tends to make people hide, freeze, blame someone else or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is more likely to lead to repair.

For example: A teenager breaks his mum's favourite mug. Guilt says, "I should tell her and help pay for a new one." Shame says, "I ruin everything," and he hides the pieces in the bin.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What exactly did I do? What would make it right?" "I made a mistake. I am not a mistake."

TRY THIS:

Next time you feel bad about something, ask: is this about what I did, or who I am? If it's who you are, turn it into one thing you did.

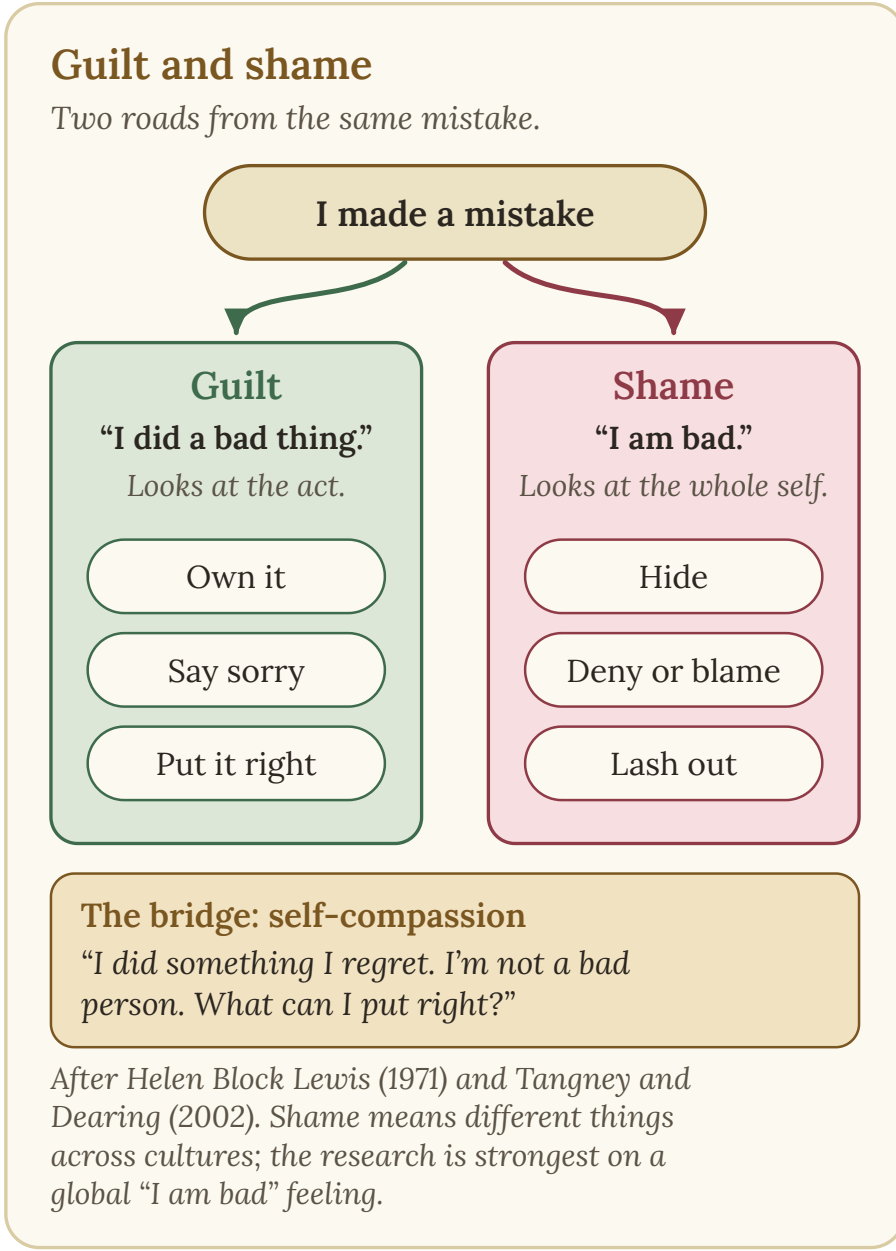


FIGURE 8 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

03

Shame makes you want to hide.

Shame shows up in the body first: a hot face, eyes down, a sinking stomach, wanting the floor to swallow you. It can also come out sideways, as sudden anger or a cold, closed face. That's why a small comment can start a big fight: it touched shame, and shame defends.

For example: A coworker says in a meeting, "Didn't we already cover this?" His colleague snaps back. Later she realises the snap wasn't about the question. She felt stupid in front of everyone.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think I felt embarrassed just then, and it came out sharp. Can I try again?"

TRY THIS:
Learn your own shame signs. Next time you suddenly want to disappear or snap, name it quietly: "That's shame."

04

The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh voice usually started as protection. If you criticise yourself first, maybe nobody else can hurt you. If you're hard on yourself, maybe you'll never fail again. It meant well. But a voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, and it is tiring to live with.

For example: A young dad tells himself "idiot" every time he forgets something for the baby. His own father used that word. The voice is old, borrowed and not his.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Thanks for trying to protect me. I can take it from here."
"Whose voice is that, really?"

TRY THIS:

Write down one thing your inner critic says often. Then ask: would I say this to a friend I love? What would I say instead?

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Flip it

Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work

Flip it

What's on your mind?

I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone A worry *Being hard on myself* Anger

THE FLIP

What a good friend might say
"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

Kinder words for yourself
"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll [one thing]."

One next step
[one small thing, like a short sorry, a reminder on your phone, or some rest]

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Hamish's own words, after changing the flip
I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.

His next step
Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

05

Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you would treat a good friend who is struggling. One well-known model has three parts: kindness instead of attack, remembering that everyone struggles, and noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest

people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve, not less.

For example: A woman fails her driving test for the third time. Instead of "I'm hopeless," she tries: "This is hard. Lots of people need more goes. What will I practice before the next one?" She books another lesson.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"This is a hard moment." "Other people feel this too." "What do I need right now?"

TRY THIS:

Put a hand on your chest or arm, if that feels okay, and say those three lines slowly to yourself once today.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first can help.

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

We all measure ourselves against others. It's how humans work out where they stand. But feeds full of other people's best moments make that measuring unfair. Self-esteem that depends on being better than others goes up and down a lot. Self-compassion doesn't need you to win.

For example: Two old friends meet up. One has a new house, the other is renting a room. The renter spends the evening quietly

ranking herself, and misses that her friend is lonely and wanted to talk.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"I'm comparing my inside to their outside." "Their good news doesn't take anything from me."

TRY THIS:
Notice one comparison today. Then swap it for a question about the other person: "How are you, really?"

07

You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake is easier when it doesn't mean you're worthless. A simple shape helps: say what you did, say the effect, say what you'll do now. Then stop. You don't need to beat yourself up as proof that you're sorry.

For example: A housemate forgot to pay her share of the bill, and the internet was cut off. "I forgot to pay. That left you without internet all weekend. I've paid it and set a reminder." Done, without a speech about being a terrible person.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I did this. I can see it affected you like this. Here's what I'm doing about it."

TRY THIS:
Think of one small thing you still feel bad about. Write the three-part sentence. Decide whether to send it, say it or simply let it rest.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Owning a mistake can be short and plain: what happened, that it was yours, what you'll do. If it went wrong in a talk, the step-by-step reset helps you find the words.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

08

Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they are treated, and adults keep learning it. How we talk to each other matters: "you did a careless thing" leaves room to change; "you're so careless" doesn't. Praise for effort and for who someone is, not only for results, helps people feel they matter on bad days too.

For example: A team lead starts each project review with "what did we learn?" instead of "who got it wrong?" Over time, people own up to problems earlier.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm glad you're here, whatever happened today." "That didn't work. You're still welcome here."

TRY THIS:

Say one thing to someone today that isn't about their results: "I like how you…" or "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Part One: who you are today (page 27)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

You write one line to the team: "Sorry for the mix-up with yesterday's file, the right one is attached." Then you notice the old voice and talk back to it the way you would to a friend: "You made a mistake. You fixed it. That's what a decent colleague does." The voice gets quieter. Nobody mentions the file again, and by lunch you've stopped thinking about it too.

In everyday life

- **Partners:** "You forgot to call" lands as "you're a terrible partner," and the reply comes out as a defence instead of a sorry.
- **Parents and children:** A child who is told "you're so naughty" hears who they are. "That was a naughty thing to do" leaves them a way back.
- **Friends:** One friend always says yes to everything, then quietly burns out, because saying no feels like risking being dropped.
- **Work:** Someone hides a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proving they don't belong there.
- **Community:** A newcomer at a club makes one mistake, feels everyone saw, and never comes back.

On your own: a kinder voice to keep

You don't need anyone else to start this. You only need to notice how you talk to yourself, and to practice one gentler sentence.

- Catch the critic's favourite words: "always," "useless," "pathetic," "should."
- Swap one of them for a fact: "I was late twice this week" instead of "I'm hopeless."
- Keep a short list of things you did well, or simply did, on hard days. Getting up counts.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I'm allowed to be a work in progress." "I can be disappointed in what I did and still be on my own side."

Common mix-ups

- **"Self-compassion is self-pity."** Self-pity says "only me, poor me." Self-compassion says "this is hard, and other people go through it too." It connects you to others.
- **"If I'm kind to myself, I'll get lazy."** Research suggests the opposite is more common: fear of your own attack makes people avoid trying and hide mistakes.
- **"Self-worth means thinking I'm great."** It doesn't. It means you matter even on the days you're not great.
- **"Feeling shame means I'm a bad person."** Shame is a feeling, not a fact. Almost everyone feels it.
- **"Owning a mistake means agreeing I'm worthless."** The opposite. You can only really own a mistake when it doesn't threaten your whole self.
- **"I should just feel confident."** Confidence comes and goes. Kindness towards yourself is something you can practice on the days it's gone.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Separate the person from the act.** Talk about what happened, never about what kind of person they are.
- **Don't argue with their shame.** "You're not useless!" can feel like being told they're wrong to feel it. Try: "It sounds like you feel really low about it. I don't see you that way."
- **Make repair easy.** Help them find one small thing they can do, so the feeling has somewhere to go.
- **Notice them on ordinary days.** Kindness when nothing has gone wrong teaches worth best.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"That sounds like it's weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?" "You don't have to earn being cared about."

When to get more help

Everyone feels shame and self-doubt sometimes. It's worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if harsh thoughts about yourself are there most days, if they stop you working, eating, sleeping or seeing people, or if you feel you deserve to be hurt. Therapies such as compassion-focused therapy and cognitive behavioural therapy are built to help with exactly this.

If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If someone close to you keeps telling you you're worthless, stupid or lucky to have them, that isn't a self-esteem problem. It can be a way of controlling someone. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? have free, private help.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a feeling that is too big to think through

- Ask Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

Reading pages to read on the website

- Shame and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), in the site's library of research notes
- Self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and self-esteem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation)
- Perfectionism and social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life)
- Masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), for anyone who has spent years trying to seem "normal"
- Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up), for where an old inner voice might have started

More for your situation

- **On your own:** Part One: where you came from (page 7) · Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · On my own after a breakup (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Teens:** For teens: feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Neurodivergent:** Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) · Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **At work:** At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Coming out:** Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Carers and parents:** Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)

- **More in Part Three:** Loss, grief and big life changes (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss) · Minds that work differently (page 119)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Your worth isn't a score.** It doesn't rise and fall with each day's results.
- ✓ **Guilt and shame are different.** Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right.
- ✓ **Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.** Being kind to yourself after a mistake makes it easier to own it and grow.
- ✓ **Worth is something we can give.** How we treat each other teaches people what they are worth.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from
Old rules that taught you your worth page 7

Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
Kindness when a goal slips page 49

Book 2 · Healing after hurt
Guilt, apology and forgiveness Heal and Steady

Book 2 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When the inner critic gets loud Heal and Steady

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Ask Professor Puddles
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth-in-depth

6

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 6 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

Personality, temperament and change across life

What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Traits are dials, not boxes
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are about fit, not fault
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Traits are dials, not boxes.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are. What happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average, people grow steadier and more organised as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.

- **Different isn't wrong.** Most clashes between personalities are about fit, not fault.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The Wiring Card and Wavelength** (Part One, Now (page 27)) describe how you lean on a few dials, not which box you are in. Most clashes are about fit, not fault.
- **One owner per job** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) lets people with different temperaments share a home or team without changing who they are: you arrange the jobs around the differences. Big idea: *fix the setup, not the person.*

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

It's your aunt's seventieth birthday. You're standing quietly by the cake when she says, loud enough for everyone: "Oh, you were always the shy one!" Everyone laughs. You smile, but something stings. You're forty-two. You teach thirty children every day. Are you still "the shy one"? Were you ever?

We all describe people by their personality: "She's so laid-back," "He's a worrier," "They're the organised one." Descriptions like these can turn into boxes. This chapter looks at how personality actually works, what stays the same, and what changes.

01

Traits are dials, not boxes.

Personality is your usual pattern of thinking, feeling and acting. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five": **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organised and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness** (warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them. Each one is a dial, not a switch. Most people sit somewhere in the middle of most dials.

For example: Two friends take a quiz. One gets "introvert," the other "extravert." When they look at their actual scores, they are only a few points apart, both near the middle.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I'm more of this than that, some of the time." "A label is a summary, not a whole person."

TRY THIS:
For each of the five dials, mark where you think you sit, from one to ten. Then ask: where would a close friend put you?

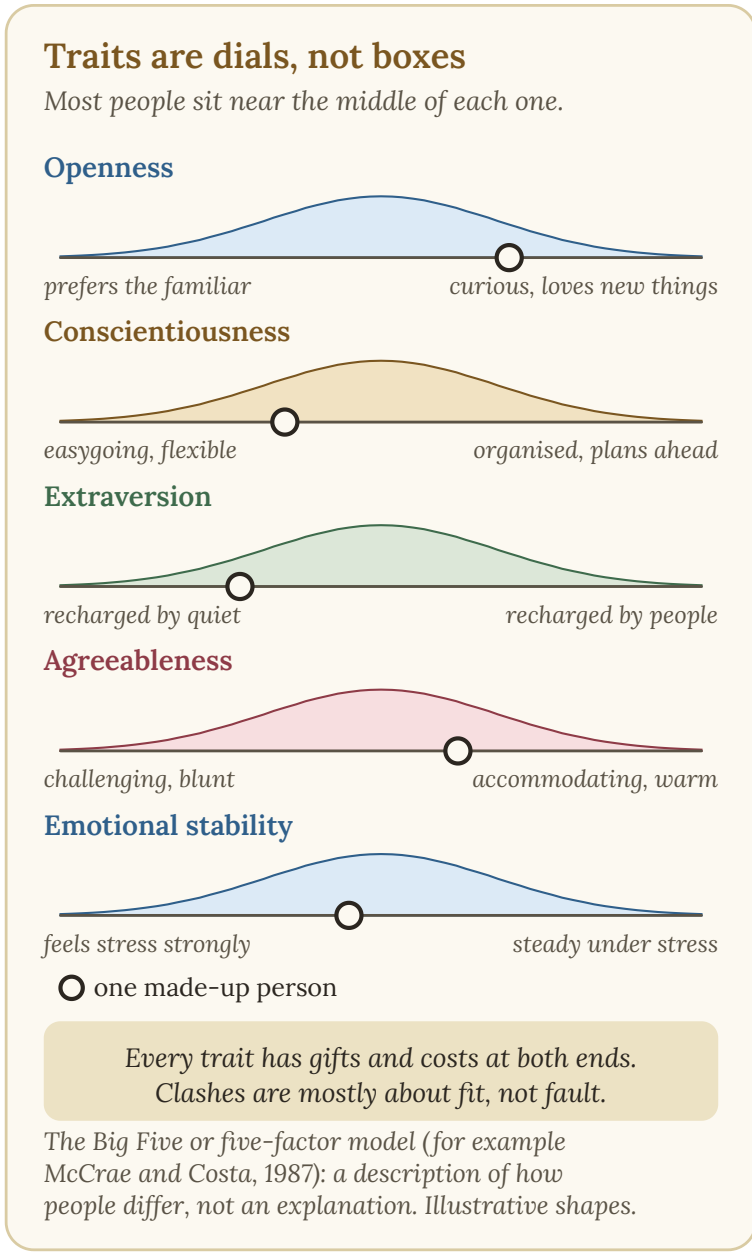


FIGURE 9 Traits are dials, not boxes: most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

02

Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality we can see from very early on. Some babies are very active, some calm; some settle easily into new routines, others take time; some react strongly to noise or change. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences, and the idea of "goodness of fit": how well a child's temperament fits what the people and places around them expect.

For example: A slow-to-warm-up toddler cries at every new playgroup. Her mum stops pushing her to join in straight away and lets her watch from her lap for ten minutes first. By the third week, she joins in on her own.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready."
> (to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made, not a flaw."

> TRY THIS:
> Think about what you were like as a small child, from what family say or what you remember. What seems the same now? What seems different?

03

Situations matter too.

Personality is a pattern, not a rule. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, organised in their job and messy at home, patient with children and short with call centres. A trait tells you what someone tends to do across many situations, not what they will do in this one.

For example: A manager thinks a new colleague is "cold." At the team's charity football match, the same colleague is chatty, funny and warm. The office was the thing that was quiet, not him.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"I've only seen them in one setting." "Where am I most myself, and where am I least?"

TRY THIS:

Before deciding what someone is "like," try to see them in one different setting, or ask them about one.

04

Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often enjoy people very much, but find busy, noisy social time uses up energy, and need quiet to recover. People who are more extraverted often feel energised by company and busy places. Most of us are a mix (sometimes called ambivert). Neither is better. They just need different things to feel at their best.

For example: After a wedding, one partner wants to go on to the after-party; the other wants bed and silence. They agree: one goes for an hour, the other goes home, and they have breakfast together.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I loved tonight, and I'm out of social energy. It's not about you." "Shall we go together, and I'll head home at ten?"

TRY THIS:

Notice what refills you after a busy week: company, quiet, or a bit of both. Plan one of those this weekend.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: some of us recharge at the park with everyone, and some under a quiet blanket. Both are great! A quiz can show you your own style.

TOOL **Communication style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

05

People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable, but it isn't fixed. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organised, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness kept growing right across the lifespan. Big life events, roles and relationships all play a part.

For example: A man who was a nervous, disorganised student becomes a calm, steady nurse in his forties. His friends from school barely recognise him. He says, "Life kept asking me to cope, and slowly I learned how."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Who I was at fifteen isn't who I have to be now." "People I knew years ago may have changed too."

TRY THIS:

Write down one way you have changed in the last ten years. What helped it happen?

06

You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

People who want to change a trait can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways, again and again. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended, over sixteen weeks, to change in the direction they wanted. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially towards more emotional steadiness.

For example: A woman who wants to be less shy at work makes one small plan: say one thing in each team meeting. After two months, speaking up feels ordinary.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I don't have to become a different person. I can practise one different thing."

> TRY THIS:
> Pick one small action that fits who you'd like to be more of, like "reply to messages the same day" or "say hello first." Do it three times this week. See Chapter 6 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change) on habits.

07

Every trait has gifts and costs.

There isn't a "good" personality. Each trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are kind and easy to be with, and may find it hard to say no. Very conscientious people are reliable, and may struggle to rest. People high in openness love new things, and may get bored with routine. Knowing your mix helps you use the gifts and plan for the costs.

For example: A highly organised woman feels irritated by her relaxed housemate. Then the boiler breaks, and the housemate is the one who stays calm and finds a plumber at 10pm. She starts to see his calm as a strength.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What is the gift in this trait, and what is the cost?" "What they do that annoys me might be the flip side of something I value."

TRY THIS:

Pick one trait of yours that people sometimes complain about. Write down one time it helped.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Every trait has gifts and costs. Writing down what helps you on a one-page card turns a "flaw" into useful information.

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

Differences are about fit, not fault.

When two people with different personalities share a home, a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one, a planner and someone spontaneous, a talker and someone who needs quiet: neither is wrong. What helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions. If something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 9 (page 119) may help.

For example: A couple fight about holidays: one wants every hour planned, the other wants to wander. They agree on one plan for the morning and a free afternoon. They both enjoy it more.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're just made differently here. What would work for both of us?" "I'm a planner and you're not. Can we plan half and leave half?"

TRY THIS:

Think of one person you clash with. Name the difference without blame: "I like ___; they like ___." Then think of one small arrangement that would suit you both.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

Wavelength

Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum

Wavelength: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)
Mo

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk

Need a moment, or a day, to think first

A sudden change of plans feels…

Fine, maybe even fun Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

The why and the big vision The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

MO'S FOUR LEANINGS (HIS WAVE CODE: S F N A)

What each letter means
Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow
Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

Watch for
agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's Wavelength statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.

Fill in your own: Wavelength (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practise one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

Later, as people are leaving, you sit down next to your aunt. "I was the shy one, wasn't I," you say. "I still like quiet. These days I stand in front of thirty children every morning." She laughs. "Well, I was a terror at your age, and look at me now: I do flower arranging." You both laugh. You were never just "the shy one." Neither of you is who you were at ten, and that's fine.

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you plan a life that suits you: how much company, how much quiet, how much routine, how much new. "I'm just not a people person" might be true, or an old label worth testing.

- **With a partner:** Different traits are normal. A shared plan ("I'll handle bills; you handle holidays") often works better than trying to change each other. See When we keep having the same fight (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner).
- **With friends:** A quiet friend who doesn't text much may still care a great deal. Ask what kind of contact suits them. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Parents and children:** A child's temperament isn't a sign of good or bad parenting. Adjusting to fit them is a skill, not giving in. See For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents).
- **Family:** Family roles ("the clever one," "the difficult one") can stick long after they stop fitting. You're allowed to grow out of them.

- **At work:** Teams need a mix. Ask "How do you like to work?" rather than guessing from a quiz. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).

Common mix-ups

- **"You're either an introvert or an extravert."** Most people are somewhere in the middle, and it can shift with setting and mood.
- **"Personality is set by adulthood."** It keeps changing, slowly, across the whole of life.
- **"Some personalities are better."** Every trait has gifts and costs. What matters is fit and how you use it.
- **"Online type quizzes tell you who you are."** Many popular quizzes sort people into a handful of types. Real people are spread along each dial, not sorted into groups. Use quizzes for fun and conversation, not as a label. That includes this book's own Wave Code: four leanings on four dials, not a box.
- **"They're just difficult."** "Difficult" often means "different from me." It can also hide stress, illness or a need nobody has asked about.
- **"Changing would mean being fake."** Practising something new feels unnatural at first. Over time, it becomes part of you.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Drop the old labels.** Notice if you still describe someone the way they were years ago, and look for who they are now.

- **Ask, don't type.** "What helps you recharge?" or "How do you like to plan things?" beats guessing from their personality.
- **Notice growth out loud.** "You handled that so calmly" can help someone see a change they hadn't noticed.
- **Don't use personality as a weapon.** "You're so uptight" or "You're just lazy" closes doors. Describe the action, not the person.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I used to think of you as the shy one. I don't think that fits any more." "What do you need to be at your best this week?"

When to get more help

Personality differences are normal and don't need fixing. It may be worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or psychologist if:

- a pattern in how you feel, think or relate to people keeps causing you or others real distress, across many parts of life;
- you feel very unsure who you are, or your moods swing so much it's hard to cope;
- worry, low mood or fear of people is stopping you from living the life you want.

Please don't diagnose yourself or anyone else with a "personality disorder" from what you read online. Those are clinical terms that only a qualified professional can use, after a proper assessment.

A personality trait never excuses controlling, frightening or hurtful behaviour. If you're afraid of someone close to you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Wavelength (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength): four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz).

Reading pages to read on the website

- Know your own wiring: how you tend to feel, react and recharge.
- The library: the Big Five (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), introversion, morning and evening people and highly sensitive people.

More for your situation

- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 27)
- Part Three, Chapter 6: Habits and change
- Part Three, Chapter 9: Minds that work differently (page 119)
- For parents · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · At work
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Traits are dials, not boxes.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- ✓ **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are. What happens next matters too.
- ✓ **People keep changing.** On average, people grow steadier and more organised as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.
- ✓ **Different isn't wrong.** Most clashes between personalities are about fit, not fault.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Your wiring today page 27

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from
Temperament and how you grew up page 7

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently
Minds that work differently page 119

Book 2 · Habits and change
How change really happens Heal and Steady

PUT IT TO USE

Wavelength
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-14-personality-in-depth

7

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 7 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

Minds that work differently

How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why they are differences and not character flaws, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognising faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. When to get more help
25. Tools and reading on this site
26. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** Different isn't broken, and differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.

- **Overload isn't a choice.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- **Some things help a lot:** less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests, and real rest.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The Wiring Card and "know how you like to be spoken to"** (Part One, Now (page 27)) work because different minds need different input. Saying things plainly is an adjustment that helps almost everyone. Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*
- **One owner per job and the written job list** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper. That helps ADHD and autistic minds most, and everyone a little. Big idea: *fix the setup, not the person.*

MONDAY, 8:15AM

"Can you just put your shoes on?" For the third time. Your child is lying on the hall floor, hands over his ears, because the new socks "feel wrong." You're late. He's not being difficult. To him, the sock seam feels like sandpaper, and the alarm clock is still ringing in his head.

This chapter is for anyone: neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and the people who live, work and learn with them. It explains how these minds work first, then what helps. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the labels you use for yourself.

01

Brains vary, like bodies do.

People's brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with others. "Neurodiversity" is the idea that this variety is natural. "Neurodivergent" describes people whose minds work differently from what is treated as typical. Different isn't broken. And at the same time, differences can be disabling, especially when the world is built for one kind of mind.

For example: A man who struggled all through school finds out at 40 that he is dyslexic. He's relieved: he was never lazy or stupid. His brain just processes written words differently.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

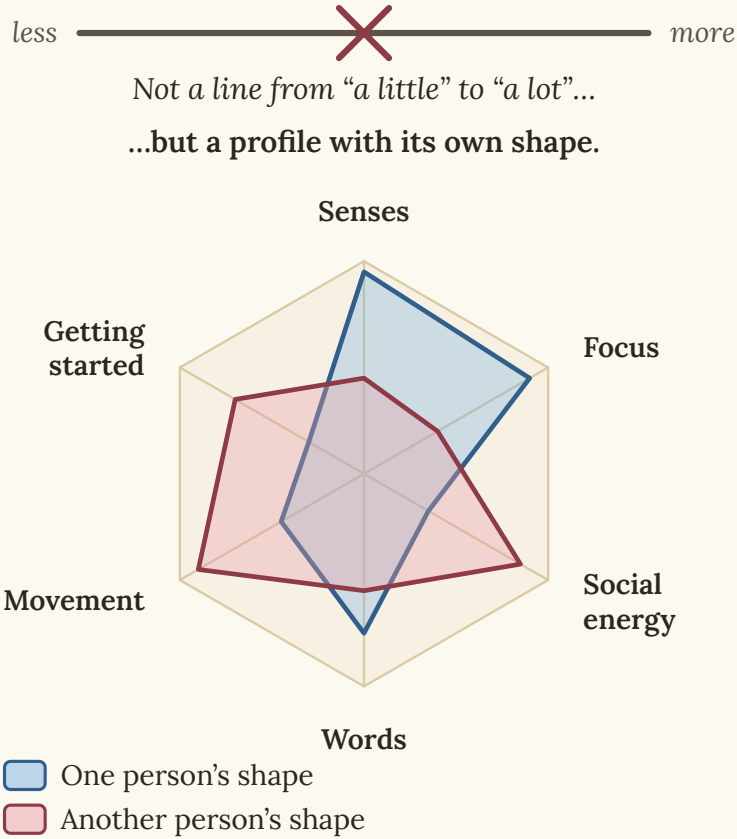
"Maybe this isn't a flaw. Maybe it's a difference that needs a different setup."

TRY THIS:

Think of one thing that's hard for you that's easy for others. Ask: is it effort, or is it a different kind of brain?

Brains vary, like bodies do

Different, not broken.



Strong in some places, stretched in others.
Ask what helps, and say what helps you.

Illustration, not a test. "Spiky profile" is a common way to describe uneven strengths and needs.

FIGURE 10 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot". Different, not broken.

02

Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally, have deep and focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely, and find predictability calming. Autism isn't a line from "mild" to "severe." Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change day to day. Misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

For example: An autistic coworker says, "Your slides have three typos." She means it as help. Her colleague hears criticism. Neither is wrong; they're using different rules for what kind means.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I like it when people say exactly what they mean. You can be direct with me." "Do you want my honest view, or just support right now?"

TRY THIS:

In one conversation today, say exactly what you mean, with no hints. Notice whether it makes things easier.

03

ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD often have plenty of attention, but find it hard to point it where they choose. Boring tasks can feel impossible; interesting ones can swallow hours. Time can feel slippery ("now" and "not now"), and feelings can come fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself, not a lack of effort or care.

For example: A woman with ADHD forgets her friend's birthday, then spends six hours making her an amazing handmade card. The

forgetting and the focus come from the same brain.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I care about this. My brain drops things. A reminder really helps, and it doesn't annoy me."

TRY THIS:

Move one thing you keep forgetting out of your head and into the world: an alarm, a note on the door, or a basket by the exit.

04

Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise or scratchy clothes. Others need more input: movement, strong flavours, pressure. Overload isn't being fussy. It's a body at its limit.

For example: Two housemates argue about the kitchen radio. One finds silence eerie; the other finds the radio painful. A rule helps: radio on mornings, headphones in the evening.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"It's not you. The noise in here is too much for me right now. Can we move somewhere quieter?"

TRY THIS:

Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you, and one that calms you. Make one small change today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is useful information, not a complaint. A one-page card lets you share what helps, in your own words.

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, not a measure of how clever someone is. Many people have a "spiky" profile: very strong in some areas, struggling in others. The right tools, like audiobooks, spoken notes or extra time, can level the ground.

For example: A teenager with dyspraxia is called clumsy at football. In drama, he writes and directs the school play. Same boy, different task.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I learn better when I can listen than when I read. Could you send a voice note instead?"

TRY THIS:

Ask someone you live or work with: "What's the easiest way for you to take in information?" Then use it.

06

Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences: copying others, forcing eye contact, holding back movements, rehearsing small talk. This is called masking. It can help someone

get through a day, but it uses a lot of energy, and over years it can lead to exhaustion, anxiety and burnout.

For example: A student seems fine all day at college, then comes home and can't speak for an hour. She's not being rude. She's recovering from a day of performing.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I need some quiet time after work. It's how I recharge, not a sign I'm upset with you."

> TRY THIS:
> Notice one place where you can drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with. Spend a bit more time there.

07

Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and often lasts months. Rest, fewer demands and less masking help. Pushing harder usually makes it worse.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm in burnout. I need fewer demands for a while, not a pep talk." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

TRY THIS:

If you think you might be in burnout, list three demands you could drop, delay or share for a month. If it goes on, or you feel hopeless, talk to a doctor.

08

Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much: crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload. What helps is less: less noise, fewer words, fewer questions, more space and safety. Talking can wait.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

(to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk."
(for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

TRY THIS:

On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

09

Stimming helps, so let it be.

Stimming means repeated movements or sounds, like rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing or fiddling with something. Most people stim a little (think of a jiggling foot). For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to

stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Rocking helps me think. It doesn't mean anything's wrong."
"You don't need to stop. It's fine with me."

TRY THIS:
Notice what your own hands or body do when you're stressed, focused or happy. That's your stim.

10

Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds, often autistic and ADHD ones, focus deeply on one thing at a time. That focus can be a gift: real expertise, flow and joy. It also makes switching tasks hard, so being interrupted can feel like being pulled out of water. Warnings before a change, and routines, help a lot.

For example: A dad calls his daughter to dinner three times and gets more frustrated each time. Then he tries a ten-minute warning, and a five. She comes to the table calm.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Dinner is in ten minutes. I'll come and get you at five to." "Can you give me a warning before we switch?"

TRY THIS:
Before you interrupt someone who's focused, give a heads-up and a time. See if it goes more smoothly.

11

Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can I tell you about this for five minutes? It's how I unwind."
> "Tell me more. What's the best bit?"

TRY THIS:
Ask someone about their favourite subject, and let them talk for five minutes without steering.



TIDBIT
Tidbit wants you to know: this site can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. Ooh, try it!

TOOL **Make the site fit your mind** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

12

Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, explicit words help everyone: say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. Changes made for one person, like quiet spaces, written agendas or flexible hours, often help many others too.

For example: A team starts sending meeting agendas a day early. It was for one autistic colleague. Soon everyone says meetings are shorter and better.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What would make this easier for you?" "Here's what helps me. What helps you?"

TRY THIS:

Swap one "how I work best" fact with someone today: one thing that helps you, and ask for one that helps them.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

Wiring Card for work

Tom, autistic, for his new manager

Your card

Who it's for

A partner · Family · A friend · *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

Tom

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
A written list.

I take words
Literally.

Give me time to answer
Write it down so I can answer later.

Please avoid
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

A request lands best as
"Could you ___ by ___?"

Also good to know about me
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

Sensory needs
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.

Fill in your own: Wiring Card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

13

Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, support and community. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person"; others prefer "person with autism." The kindest rule is simple: ask, and use the words the

person chooses. And never try to diagnose someone else, especially in an argument.

For example: During a row, a partner says, "You're so autistic." It lands as an insult and ends the talk. Later, he apologises and asks what his partner actually needs.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"How do you like to describe yourself?" "I'm wondering if I might be neurodivergent. I'd like to find out more."

TRY THIS:
If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed, and decide one small next step: reading, talking to someone, or asking a doctor.

14
Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they are autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties, fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed how they understood their lives. Relief, grief and joy can all come together.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I've just found out I'm autistic. I'm still working out what it means." "That explains so much about my life."

TRY THIS:

If you've found out later in life, look for one autistic-led group, book or online space, and give yourself time to make sense of it.

15

Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, on some days more than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. It isn't laziness. It's the brain's self-management system working differently, and it often helps to move the managing out of your head and into the world.

For example: A woman can write a brilliant report but can't get herself to post a parcel. Putting the parcel by the door, with a sticky note and a phone alarm, gets it done.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Could you send me that as a list? Spoken steps fall out of my head." "I'm not ignoring it. Starting is the hard bit for me."

TRY THIS:

Pick one task that keeps not happening. Make the first step tiny and visible: a note, an alarm, or the thing left where you'll trip over it. See routines that help (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) and Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently).

16

When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, distracting or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It is not in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it: a review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Whatever it is called, what helps tends to be the same: less pressure, more choice, and requests that feel like invitations.

For example: A boy who refuses "Put your coat on now" happily puts it on when his dad says, "It's cold out. Coat or jumper, your choice."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I wonder if we could…" "No rush. Which would you rather?" (for yourself) "Being told makes it harder. Can I choose when?"

TRY THIS:
Turn one daily instruction into a choice or an invitation this week, and see what changes.

17

Not recognising faces isn't rudeness.

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognise people's faces, sometimes even close friends out of context. It can be something you're born with, and it often runs in families (NHS). Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People

who don't recognise you may be relying on voices, hair, clothes or where they usually see you.

For example: A man walks past his neighbour in the supermarket without a word. She feels snubbed. Later he explains he didn't recognise her without her dog. Now she says hello first, with her name.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

TRY THIS:

If faces are hard for you, tell one or two people you see often. If not, try saying your name when you greet someone out of context.

18

Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes, or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication): typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing; a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest starting point is to presume competence: assume the person understands and has something to say, and give them the time and tools to say it.

For example: At a family meal, a non-speaking teenager types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her in front of her. Now he waits, reads her reply, and answers her directly.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Take your time. I'll wait." "Would you rather type or point?" (for yourself) "I can't talk right now. I can type."

TRY THIS:

Talk to the person, not about them. Wait longer than feels natural for an answer.

19

Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding: in a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

But people don't always respond well, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many people share a little at a time, starting with what helps rather than a label.

For example: On a second date, a woman says, "I'm autistic, so I'm pretty direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in a loud bar." Her date says, "Honestly, same."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

TRY THIS:

Write one sentence about what helps you, without a label. Practise it. You can add the label later if and when you want to.

20

Finding your people.

Many autistic people describe finding other autistic people as a turning point: not having to translate, explain or mask. Research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community, not only a diagnosis.

For example: After a late diagnosis, a man joins an online group for autistic adults who love maps. For the first time, a conversation doesn't tire him out.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"There are people who work like me." "I can belong somewhere without masking."

TRY THIS:

Look for one autistic-led group, book, podcast or online space about something you love.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works, say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Part One: who you are today (page 27)

MONDAY, 8:30AM

You stop asking. You sit on the hall floor next to him and say quietly, "Socks feel wrong?" He nods. You switch off the alarm clock that's still beeping in the bedroom and fetch the old seamless pair. Two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late, and nobody shouted. That evening you order three more pairs of the seamless socks, and he chooses the colours.

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout early. See Get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path).

- **With a partner:** Swap "how I work best" notes: how you like plans, messages, touch and time alone. See Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).
- **Parents and children:** Behaviour often has a sensory or overload reason. Ask "What's too much right now?" before "Why are you doing this?"
- **With friends:** A friend who cancels at the last minute may be out of energy, not out of care. Offer easy options, like a walk or a message.
- **At work:** Written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help many people, not only neurodivergent ones. See Neurodiversity at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **If you have ADHD and share a home:** Make the chore tools lighter. Log three days, not seven, with a tally on the fridge.

Own a few jobs completely, each with a labelled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"Everyone's a bit autistic."** Everyone has some traits in common, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life. The phrase can make real needs sound small.
- **"ADHD just means you can't sit still."** Many people with ADHD, especially girls and women, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside.
- **"They seem fine to me."** Masking can hide a lot. Seeming fine isn't the same as being fine.
- **"Adjustments are special treatment."** They remove barriers so people can do what's expected. Glasses aren't special treatment either.
- **"Autistic people lack empathy."** Many feel others' feelings strongly. Differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Believe them** about what's hard, what hurts and what helps, even if it's different for you.
- **Be clear.** Say what you mean, give times, and write down anything important.
- **Ask, don't assume.** Every neurodivergent person is different. "What helps you?" beats any list.

- **Protect their energy.** Quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places aren't extras.
- **Enjoy their interests.** Listening to someone talk about what they love is one of the warmest things you can do.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

When to get more help

If you wonder whether a difference is part of ongoing difficulties at school, work or home, for you or someone you care for, a doctor, school support staff or a psychologist can talk you through an assessment. Waiting lists can be long, so start early and write down what you notice.

Burnout, depression and anxiety are more common among neurodivergent people, often because of the stress of living in a world that doesn't fit. If you're exhausted most days, losing skills you used to have, or feeling hopeless, please talk to a doctor. **If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself,** please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

A difference never excuses harm, and it never makes someone deserve harm. If someone uses your differences to control or belittle you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz) for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

Reading pages to read on the website

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): a one-page "how I communicate" card to share
- Wired differently: neurodiversity and communication, including the double empathy problem
- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)
- Research notes: autism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), ADHD, monotropism, masking, sensory profiles and sensory load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress)

More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work · Autistic at work
- **Teens:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring · Part One: who you are today (page 27)
- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85) · Loss, grief and big life changes

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you're autistic, or wondering, these are written with you in mind: masking and autistic burnout earlier in this chapter; the double empathy problem, on why misunderstandings run both ways; when feelings are hard to name (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings-in-depth) (alexithymia) in Chapter 1; the wiring card, a one-page "how I work best" card to share; and Autistic at work, with words for asking for what you need.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Brains vary, like bodies do.** Different isn't broken, and differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.
- ✓ **Overload isn't a choice.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- ✓ **Some things help a lot:** less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests, and real rest.
- ✓ **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Getting to know your own wiring
page 27

Book 3 · Why we get out of tune
Pace, tone and meeting in the middle
Understanding Each Other

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change
Dials, not boxes
page 103

Book 3 · How communication works
Saying it so it lands for different minds
Understanding Each Other

PUT IT TO USE

Communication style quiz
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

The wiring card
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 27)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

In: Who you are becoming (page 49)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 27), Who you are becoming (page 49), How feelings work (page 67)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85)

TOOL **Turn a complaint into a request** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85)

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: How feelings work (page 67)

TOOL **Communication style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

In: Where your lens came from (page 7), Your wiring, weather and words (page 27), Who you are becoming (page 49), Personality, temperament and change (page 103)

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 27), Personality, temperament and change (page 103), Minds that work differently (page 119)

TOOL **Where a reaction comes from** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Where your lens came from (page 7), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85)

TOOL **Upset right now? A 5-minute calm-down** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How feelings work (page 67), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85)

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 27), How feelings work (page 67)

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85)

TOOL **Ask a question in your own words** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85)

TOOL **Make the site fit your mind** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page 119)

TOOL **Calm football game for small kind acts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Who you are becoming (page 49)

TOOL **Handoff-bag checklist for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Who you are becoming (page 49)

TOOL **Room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

In: Where your lens came from (page 7), Your wiring, weather and words (page 27), Who you are becoming (page 49), Personality, temperament and change (page 103), Minds that work differently (page 119)

TOOL **10-minute team check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: How feelings work (page 67), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 85), Personality, temperament and change (page 103)

TOOL **Connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Where your lens came from (page 7), Your wiring, weather and words (page 27), Who you are becoming (page 49)

TOOL **Start in 10 minutes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes`

In: Who you are becoming (page 49)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia
Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

A bid
A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Double empathy
The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

If-then plan
A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

Kinship care
When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure

Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Wave Code

Four letters from the Wavelength quiz, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes

The 105 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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The series

Spread Love & Acceptance is a series of short books. Each one stands on its own; read them in any order.

Book 1	**Know Yourself Kindly** *(this book)* Start with yourself: your history, your wiring, your feelings, your worth and how your mind works.
Book 2	**Heal and Steady** For the heavy days: stress, anger, worry and low mood, grief, repair, change and what matters to you.
Book 3	**Understanding Each Other** Pace and tone, how words land, how we see each other, belonging, love, groups and helping well.
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